

Contents

Preface	xiii
Acknowledgments	xv
NICCOLÒ MACHIAVELLI	I
<i>The Prince</i> (written 1513, published 1532)	4
Dedication	4
Chapter 1: How many kinds of principalities there are, and by what means they are acquired	4
Chapter 2: Concerning hereditary principalities	4
Chapter 3: Concerning mixed principalities	5
Chapter 4: Why the kingdom of Darius, conquered by Alexander, did not rebel against the successors of Alexander at his death	8
Chapter 5: Concerning the way to govern cities or principalities which lived under their own laws before they were annexed.....	9
Chapter 6: Concerning new principalities which are acquired through one's own arms and ability	10
Chapter 7: Concerning new principalities which are acquired either through the arms of others or by good fortune	11
Chapter 8: Concerning those who have obtained a principality through wickedness	14
Chapter 9: Concerning a civil principality	16
Chapter 10: Concerning the way in which the strength of all principalities ought to be measured	18
Chapter 11: Concerning ecclesiastical principalities	18
Chapter 12: Of the different types of troops and mercenaries	19
Chapter 13: Concerning auxiliary, mixed, and citizen soldiers.....	22
Chapter 14: That which concerns a prince on the subject of the art of war	23
Chapter 15: Concerning things for which men, and especially princes, are praised or blamed	24
Chapter 16: Concerning generosity and miserliness	25
Chapter 17: Concerning cruelty and mercy, and whether it is better to be loved than feared.....	26
Chapter 18: Concerning the way in which princes should keep their word	27
Chapter 19: That one should avoid being despised and hated	28
Chapter 20: Are fortresses, and many other things to which princes often resort, advantageous or hurtful?	32
Chapter 21: How a prince should act in order to gain esteem	34
Chapter 22: Concerning princes' advisors	35
Chapter 23: How to avoid flatterers	35
Chapter 24: Why the princes of Italy have lost their states	36
Chapter 25: Of fortune's power in human affairs, and how to deal with her	37
Chapter 26: An exhortation to liberate Italy from the barbarians	38
<i>Discourses on the First Ten Books of Titus Livius</i> (1512–17)	40
Niccolò Machiavelli to Zanobi Buondelmonte and Cosima Rucellai	40
from First Book	41
Introduction	41
Chapter 1: Of the Beginning of Cities in General, and Especially that of the City of Rome	41

NICCOLÒ MACHIAVELLI

(1469 – 1527)

Who Was Niccolò Machiavelli?

MACHIAVELLI, THE AUTHOR OF ONE OF THE MOST controversial texts in Western political thought, was born in 1469 in Florence, an Italian city-state. The capital of Tuscany, Florence was controlled by the great banking house of the Medici; from Machiavelli's birth until his early twenties, his city was ruled by Lorenzo the Magnificent, a prince of the Medici family. An enthusiastic patron of the arts—including Leonardo da Vinci, Botticelli, Donatello, and Michelangelo—Lorenzo made Florence a hub of humanistic Renaissance culture.¹ He died in 1492, and his successor—Piero de' Medici—abandoned the city in the face of an advancing French army in 1494. After a short-lived but disastrous period of quasi-theocratic rule under the charismatic friar Savonarola—a populist religious firebrand who had opposed the humanist rule of the Medici—the newly republican Florence governed itself until 1512, when the Medici family, with the help of the Spanish army and the support of Pope Julius II, recaptured the city.

The second son of a prominent lawyer from an old Florentine family, Machiavelli became a government clerk in 1494 and he very quickly rose to a prominent position. From the death of Savonarola—burned at the stake by the Florentine population in 1498—until the return of the Medici, Machiavelli was Second Chancellor and Secretary to the Ten of War, and he traveled on diplomatic missions to a range of princely and ecclesiastical courts across southern Europe including the king of France, the Emperor Maximilian, and the Papal Court at Rome. During this period Machiavelli visited the military campaign headquarters of the general of the Pope's armies, Cesare Borgia, a figure who

has come down through history as being notoriously ruthless and scheming but who Machiavelli is thought to have greatly admired—his exploits are frequently cited approvingly in *The Prince*.² Between 1503 and 1506 Machiavelli was in charge of the Florentine militia responsible for the defense of the city. He also organized a military force to attack Pisa, a nearby city that was in revolt against Florentine rule.³

After the return of the Medici Machiavelli was removed from office, and in 1513 he was arrested and tortured on suspicion of being involved in a plot to assassinate the Medici brothers, Giuliano and Giovanni. Even on the rack Machiavelli insisted on his innocence, and he was exiled to his family's estates in the Tuscan countryside. It was here, living in semi-seclusion with his wife Marietta and six children, that he wrote the works on which his reputation rests, *The Prince* and *Discourses on Livy*. He also wrote several other pieces, including a ribald play called *Mandragola* ("The Mandrake Root"); *Dell' Arte della*

Guerra, a book on military organization; and a history of Florence commissioned by Cardinal—later Pope—Giulio de' Medici.

In 1525 Machiavelli, now in his mid-fifties, was finally allowed to return to public life, this time in the service of the Medici family. He visited Rome to present his *History of Florence* to the Pope, and traveled to Venice—where his play had recently been performed to great acclaim—on a trade mission from Florence. However, the spring of 1527



¹ Lorenzo's collections form the core of the Uffizi museum in Florence. His banking house was also responsible for the creation of the double-entry bookkeeping system for keeping accounts.

² However, as a Florentine envoy, Machiavelli also strongly criticized Borgia. This has led some commentators to see *The Prince* as a bitter satire on contemporary political life, rather than as a manual in political expedience meant to be taken at face-value. Support for this non-standard interpretation is slim, however.

³ The attack on Pisa was successful, and that city's separatist ambitions were suppressed for a time; however in 1512 Machiavelli's citizen militia lasted just one day when confronted by a professional army come to reclaim the city for the Medici.

saw a terrible upheaval in European politics. To the shock of the continent, the city of Rome was attacked and—after the army ignored a truce agreed with Pope Clement VII—brutally sacked by an army of Germans and Spaniards commanded by the traitorous French Duke of Bourbon (who had turned against the French monarch in favor of Emperor Charles V). In the same month, the Medici were once again expelled from Florence by the rebellious republican citizenry. Machiavelli, however, lived barely long enough to see this new political turmoil: he was already seriously ill, and he died on June 21, 1527.

What Was Machiavelli's Overall Philosophical Project?

One of Machiavelli's central interests was to construct a rule-book for politics: a set of principles that would accurately predict how people will react to various pressures and crises, and thus allow the possessor of this knowledge to exert reliable influence over others—to control their behavior. In *The Prince*, his goal was to explain what a ruler needs to do to hold onto his power. In *Discourses on Livius* he offered an analysis of the early history of Rome in order to discern how the Romans had developed institutions that established a republic and then preserved it for centuries.

What Is the Structure of These Readings?

The Prince consists of a dedication to Lorenzo the Magnificent and then 26 chapters that form five general sections. Chapters 1–11 develop a taxonomy of states; chapters 12–14 deal with military affairs; 15–19 offer prescriptions on the proper character and conduct of a prince; 20–25 give advice on how princes should deal with different situations; and the final chapter is an exhortation to Italy to expel the foreign invaders—from France and the Habsburg empire—that meddled so much in the affairs of the peninsula.

Discourses on the First Ten Books of Titus Livius is a commentary on Livy's monumental history of Rome, *Ab Urbe Condita* ("From the Founding of the City"). Machiavelli's commentary is divided into three books: Book 1 deals with the internal structure of the republic; Book 2 is on warfare; and Book 3 is a treatise on the qualities desirable in a political leader.

Some Useful Background Information

i) Machiavelli lived during an era when European politics was particularly fractious and brutal. He saw first-hand the machinations that statesmen engaged in to take and hold on to power (including the secular power of the papacy), and the risks that faced them from restless citizenry, from ambitious and vainglorious lieutenants, and even the military ambitions of nearby states. Machiavelli was not a dispassionate observer of these political forces; the ostracism that he underwent after the return of the Medici in 1512 affected him deeply. He had a passionate interest in politics, and loved to consider himself part of the high affairs of great men; he saw his forced exclusion from these circles as a substantial punishment for ending up on the losing side of a power struggle. (Machiavelli spent years making strenuous efforts to win the favor of the Medici—efforts that were just beginning to bear fruit when he died.)

ii) As a youngster, living in one of the great centers of the Italian Renaissance, Machiavelli received a thorough education in the Latin classics. Like many political thinkers of his era, he was deeply impressed by the ideals of the classical Roman republic. In particular, he admired the notion of a society whose institutions fostered virtue in its citizens and encouraged their regular participation in civic life. He was also fully familiar with the classical tradition of rhetoric: the practice of speaking publicly and persuasively in order to convince others of the worthiness of one's own position and the invalidity of that of one's opponents. In the *Discourses* Machiavelli praises rhetorical contention as the basis of civic liberty.

iii) Titus Livius was born in about 59 BCE and died in 17 CE. His history of Rome originally consisted of 142 books, but of these only books 1–10 and 21–45 survived to Machiavelli's day. Although Livy wrote during the reign of the first Roman Emperor, Augustus, he is supposed to have preferred the earlier Roman republic (which lasted from 509 BCE to about 27 BCE); since his books covering the decline of the Republic and the rise of Augustus have been lost, this is not certain.

Some Common Misconceptions

i) Machiavelli's *Prince* is often thought of as a "rule-book" for aspiring (and unprincipled) politicians. However, one of the lessons that Machiavelli was most concerned to impart is that there *are* no hard-and-fast rules in politics; there is

no single “virtue” that a politician must display in every circumstance. Instead, every political situation is different and the successful ruler must have the ability to judge what is required on a particular occasion and the flexibility to do what is necessary. Furthermore, although the goal of the shrewd leader is to reduce the role of luck or fate in his affairs—to bring fortune under his control—Machiavelli emphasizes that it is never possible to do this completely. Fortune is a powerful factor in human affairs, and even the greatest leaders are to some extent at its mercy.

ii) Machiavelli is notorious for arguing that “virtuous” princes ought sometimes to act cruelly, violently, or treacherously. However, he does not claim that it is always appropriate to do so—that men who have the power to act as they like therefore have the license to do so. He makes an important distinction between coercive actions that are “well-committed” and those that are “ill-committed.” Coercion and deceit, according to Machiavelli, must be part of the prince’s toolkit when the end justifies them as means, but they are never ends in themselves.

iii) Machiavelli is sometimes seen as a proponent of opportunistic individualism, a mentor to ambitious men who seek to gain power and influence over their fellows, a sympathizer with tough-minded realists who see that they need to “beat or be beaten” in this dog-eat-dog world. But this is an anachronistic exaggeration. Machiavelli’s interest was not individualistic but patriotic—it was the welfare of the *patria*, one’s native state, that primarily motivated him. His fervent vision was the restoration of Italy to political health and power.

How Important and Influential Are These Works?

Machiavelli, quite self-consciously, wrote *The Prince* both to form another entry in a particular literary tradition and radically to break from the established pattern of that genre. From Petrarch (1304–74) onwards there had been a humanist habit of writing didactic treatises on the ideal prince, often called “mirror-of-princes” books. These works would typically begin from a discussion of general ethical principles and the role and purpose of the state, and then go on to offer prescriptions for the manner in which a prince should be educated, the qualities required in a good ruler, the relationship that should exist between a prince and his subjects, and so on. Invariably, these handbooks would be full of improving examples taken from the classical world

and bolstered with quotes from Roman historians, poets, and biographers. The central theme was that what it takes to be an effective ruler is *virtue*: princes were praised for their moral goodness, their generosity, their support of culture.

Machiavelli’s *The Prince* is patterned on this learned model, which would have been quite familiar to his readers. And, true to this form, he writes extensively about the virtue of princes. However, Machiavelli also boldly asserted that he intended to break from the received wisdom and to take a clear-eyed, non-idealistic look at the way politics *really* operates. As such, when he talks about “virtue,” he tends to mean, not moral goodness or Christian piety, but the skill required to keep control of one’s kingdom. Machiavelli was aware—indeed, he frequently emphasizes—that this was a radical departure from tradition. It is this then-novel¹ view—that rulers cannot perform their roles effectively if they are bound by the constraints of normal morality; that politics should be governed by a different set of rules than private life—that has since been most associated with Machiavelli.

This view scandalized many and made the author’s name synonymous in many quarters with “schemer”: the stock character who schemed against and manipulated the other characters in the popular Jacobean tragedies written in the first half of the seventeenth century was called “Machiavelli.” Machiavelli’s writings were almost immediately placed on the papacy’s Index of banned books, where they remained for nearly three centuries. Notwithstanding this, Machiavelli’s views became part of the common political education of European rulers for generations after his death, and the doctrine of “reason of state”—that the ruler of a state, unlike a private citizen, may have recourse to force in order to preserve his situation—became an explicit part of political thinking in modern Europe. Along with Thucydides’ *Peloponnesian War* and Hobbes’ *Leviathan* and *De Cive*, *The Prince* is one of the central statements of political realism, the theory that politics is largely a matter of power, which agents should strive to maximize.

Machiavelli’s *Discourses*, though less notorious than *The Prince*, has also been an influential work. It is widely considered the first and most important work on republicanism in the early modern era, and an important influence on the republican movements in England and Scotland in the seventeenth century and America in the eighteenth.



¹ Novel, that is, at the level of theory, rather than of practice.

The Prince (written 1513, published 1532)

Dedication

To the Magnificent Lorenzo di Piero de' Medici:¹

Those who strive to obtain the good graces of a prince² are accustomed to come before him with such things as they hold most precious, or in which they see him take most delight; thus one often sees horses, arms, cloth of gold, precious stones, and similar ornaments worthy of their greatness presented to princes.

Desiring therefore to present myself to your Magnificence with some testimony of my devotion towards you, I have looked among my possessions and not found anything which I hold more dear than, or value so much as, the knowledge I hold of the actions of great men, acquired by long experience in contemporary affairs, and a continual study of antiquity; which, having reflected upon it with great and prolonged diligence, I now send this knowledge, condensed into a little volume, to your Magnificence.

And although I may consider this work unworthy of your approval, nevertheless I trust that your humanity will lead you to judge it be acceptable; it is not possible for me to make a better gift than to offer you the opportunity of understanding in the shortest time all that it has taken me many years to learn, through many troubles and dangers. I have not decorated this work with elaborate or magnificent words, nor stuffed it with rhetoric or unnecessary ornamentation, with which so many are accustomed to embellish their works; for I have wished that it receive no honor except by consequence of its truth and the importance of its theme.

Nor do I hold with those who think it presumptuous if a man of low and humble condition dares to discuss and lay down rules for matters of concern to princes. For, just as those who draw landscapes place themselves below in the plain to contemplate the nature of the mountains and of lofty places, and in order to contemplate the plains place themselves upon high mountains, so to understand the nature of the people one must be a prince, and to understand the nature of princes one must be of the people.

Take then, your Magnificence, this little gift in the spirit in which I send it. If you read and consider it diligently, you will discover in it my great desire that you should attain that greatness which fortune and your other attributes promise for you. And if your Magnificence will at some time turn your eyes from the summit of your greatness to these lower regions, you will see how undeservedly I suffer great and continued bad fortune.

Chapter 1: How many kinds of principalities there are, and by what means they are acquired

All states, all powers that rule or have ruled over human-kind, are either republics or principalities.

Principalities are either hereditary, in which case the family has been long established; or they are new.

The new are either entirely new, as was Milan to Francesco Sforza,³ or they are, as it were, principalities annexed to the hereditary state of the prince who has acquired them, as was the kingdom of Naples to that of the King of Spain.⁴

Such dominions thus acquired are either accustomed to live under a prince, or to live in freedom. They may be acquired either by the arms of the prince himself, by those of others, or else by fortune or by ability.

Chapter 2: Concerning hereditary principalities

I will leave out all discussion on republics, since I have written of them at length elsewhere. Here I will address myself only to principalities. In doing so I will keep to the order indicated above, and discuss how such principalities are to be ruled and preserved.

I say, then, that there are fewer difficulties in holding on to hereditary states, and those long accustomed to the family of their prince, than there are in holding on to new ones. With a hereditary state, it is enough merely to not offend against custom and to deal prudently with circumstances as they arise. A prince of average ability will maintain control unless he is deprived of it by some extraordinary and ex-

1 *Lorenzo di Piero de' Medici* Ruler of Florence (1492–1519); his uncle Pope Leo X made him duke of Urbino. His daughter was Catherine de' Medici, wife of King Henry II of France.

2 *prince* This word is used here to mean a ruler in general.

3 *Francesco Sforza* Mercenary for the Duke of Milan (1401–66), then duke himself.

4 *King of Spain* Ferdinand II of Aragon, born 1452, became King of Naples after a war with France.

cessive force; and in that case, whenever anything sinister happens to the usurper, the prince may regain the state.

Here in Italy, for example, the Duke of Ferrara¹ could not have withstood the attacks of the Venetians in 1484, nor those of Pope Julius in 1510, unless he had been long established in his dominions. The hereditary prince has less cause and less need to offend; and it follows that he will be more loved; and unless extraordinary vices cause him to be hated, it is reasonable to expect that his subjects will be naturally well disposed towards him. Over the long duration of hereditary rule the memories and motives that make for change are lost, for one change always leaves the tooting for another.

Chapter 3: Concerning mixed principalities

But difficulties occur in a new principality. And if a principality is not entirely new, but is a new addition to a pre-existing state so that the whole forms a composite state, then changes arise chiefly from a difficulty which is inherent in all new principalities. This is that people hope that changing their rules will improve their situation, and their hope is what induces them to take up arms against their current ruler. In this they are deceived, and afterwards they discover through experience that they have gone from bad to worse. This is the result of another natural and common necessity, which is that a new prince must burden his new subjects with the presence of his troops, as well as with infinite other hardships associated with the establishment of a new acquisition.

In this way, you make enemies of all those whom you have injured in seizing that principality, and you are not able to keep the friends who put you there, because you cannot satisfy them in the way they expected. You also cannot take strong measures against them. For, although one may be very strong in armed forces, in entering a province one always needs the goodwill of its natives.

For these reasons, Louis the Twelfth,² King of France, quickly occupied Milan, and as quickly lost it. Lodovico's³

own forces were all that was required to turn him out the first time because those who had opened the gates to the King, finding themselves deceived in their hopes of future benefit, were unwilling to endure the ill-treatment they received from him. It is very true that, after a prince acquires rebellious provinces a second time, he does not lose them again so easily. This is because the prince will show little reluctance to take the rebellion as an opportunity to punish delinquents, to clear out anyone suspect, and to strengthen himself in the weakest places. Thus to cause Louis to lose Milan the first time it was enough for Duke Lodovico to raise insurrections on the borders, but in order for the king to lose it a second time it was necessary to bring the whole world against him, and to defeat his armies and drive them out of Italy. This follows from the causes I mentioned above.

Nevertheless, Milan drove out France the second time, just as it had the first. The general reasons for the first loss have been discussed; it remains to name those for the second, to see what resources Louis had, and how anyone in his situation might have used them to maintain himself more securely in his acquisition than did the King of France.

Those dominions which, when acquired, are added to the long held state of the ruler who acquires them are either of the same region and language, or they are not. When they are, it is easier to hold them, especially when they have not been accustomed to self-government. To hold them securely, it is enough to have destroyed the family of the prince who was ruling them, because the two peoples, preserving the same conditions in other respects, and not being unlike in customs, will live quietly together. This can be seen in the case of Brittany, Burgundy, Gascony, and Normandy, which have been bound to France for so long a time; although there may be some difference in language, nevertheless the customs are alike, and they can easily get on amongst themselves. He who has annexed such a state, if he wishes to hold it, needs only to bear in mind two considerations: first, that the family of its former lord is extinguished; and second, that neither its laws nor its taxes are altered, so that in a very short time it will be considered no different from the old principality.

But when states are acquired in a place differing in language, customs, or laws, then there are difficulties, and good fortune and great energy are needed to overcome them. One of the greatest and most effective measures is for he who has acquired the state to go and live there. This is likely to make his position more secure and durable, as it has made that of the Turks in Greece, who, notwithstanding all the other

1 *Duke of Ferrara* This appears to be a reference to two different people, Ercole I (1431–1505) and Alfonso I (1476–1534).

2 *Louis the Twelfth* King Louis XII, “Father of the People,” born 1462, King of France from 1498 until his death in 1515. He succeeded Charles VIII as King of France in 1498.

3 *Lodovico's* Duke Lodovico was Lodovico Moro, a son of Francesco Sforza, who married Beatrice d'Este. He ruled over Milan from 1494 to 1500 and died in 1510.

measures they have taken to hold that state, would not have been able to keep it if they had not settled there. If one is on the spot, one can see disorders as they spring up, and one can quickly remedy them; but if one is not at hand, one hears of troubles only when they have spread, and then one can no longer remedy them. Moreover, if you are present the country will not be pillaged by your officials. It will be good for your subjects to have their prince close at hand; those who wish to be good have more cause to love him, and those wishing to be otherwise have more cause to fear him. One who would attack such a state from the outside will think again, for as long as the prince resides there it can only be wrested from him with the greatest difficulty.

The other and better course is to establish settlements of your own people in one or two places within the state, which can act as keys to that state. If you do not establish such settlements you will need to spend a lot to keep a great number of cavalry and infantry there. But a prince does not need to spend much on colonies, for with little or no expense he can send colonists out and keep them. He offends only the minority of citizens from whom he takes lands and houses to give them to the new inhabitants; and those whom he offends remain poor and scattered and are thus never able to injure him. The rest of the citizenry, being unaffected, are easily kept quiet, and at the same time are anxious not to err for fear that they, too, will lose their property. In conclusion, these colonies are not costly; they are more faithful; they cause less injury; and the injured, as has been said, being poor and scattered, cannot do harm. This leads to the observation that men ought to be either well treated or crushed; they can avenge themselves of lighter injuries, while of more serious ones they cannot. Therefore, any injury that is done to a person ought to be of such a kind that one need not be in fear of revenge.

But if, instead of colonies, one maintains armed men in the state, one spends much more, having to consume on the garrison all the income from the state, so that the acquisition turns into a loss. Also, many more are exasperated, because the whole state is injured; the troops of the garrison will make their presence felt up and down the state, and all will become acquainted with hardship. All then become hostile, and they will be enemies who, while beaten on their own ground, will yet be able to do harm. For every reason, therefore, such guards are as useless as a colony is useful.

The prince who holds a state differing from his own in the respects described above ought to make himself the head and defender of his less powerful neighbors, and to

weaken the more powerful amongst them, taking care that no foreigner of equal power can, by any chance, get a footing there. For it will always happen that such a competitor will be brought in by those who are discontented, either through excess ambition or fear, as has been seen already. The Romans were brought into Greece by the Aetolians, and in every other country where they obtained a footing they were brought in by the inhabitants. The usual course of affairs is that, as soon as a powerful foreigner enters an area, all the subject states are drawn to him, moved by the hatred which they feel against their ruling power. This means that such a foreigner has no trouble gaining their allegiance, for the whole of them quickly rally to the state which he has acquired there. He only needs to take care that the subject states do not get hold of too much power and authority, and then with his own forces, and with their goodwill, he can easily suppress the more powerful of them, so as to remain entirely master in the country. He who does not properly manage this business will soon lose what he has acquired, and, so long as he does hold it, he will have endless difficulties and troubles.

The Romans, in the countries which they annexed, observed these measures closely; they sent colonists and maintained friendly relations with the minor powers, without increasing their strength, while they kept down the greater ones and did not allow any strong foreign powers to gain authority. Greece is a good example of a country the Romans dealt with in this way. The Romans kept the Achaeans and Aetolians friendly, defeated the kingdom of Macedonia, and drove Antiochus out. Despite their merits, the Achaeans and Aetolians were never allowed to increase their power; Philip's attempts at persuasion could not induce the Romans to befriend him without first humbling him; and Antiochus's influence could not bring the Romans to agree that he should retain any authority in Greece. The Romans did in these instances what all prudent princes ought to do: keep in mind not only present troubles, but also future ones, and prepare for them with every energy. When foreseen, they are easy to remedy, but if you wait until they approach, the medicine is no longer in time; the malady has become incurable. It happens in these cases, as the physicians say it often happens with a terrible disease: in the beginning of the sickness it is easy to cure but difficult to detect, but in the course of time, if it has not been detected or treated in the beginning, it becomes easy to detect but difficult to cure. So it happens in affairs of state. When the evils that arise have been foreseen (which only a wise

man can do), they can be quickly redressed, but when they have not been foreseen and have been permitted to grow until everyone can see them, there is no longer a remedy.

Knowing this, the Romans, foreseeing troubles, dealt with them at once. They would not let them develop, not even to avoid a war, for they knew that war is not to be avoided, but can only be put off to the advantage of others. In this case, they wished to fight with Philip and Antiochus in Greece so they would not have to do so in Italy; they could have avoided both, but did not wish to do this. Nor did the Romans ever believe the wise ones of today who are forever saying: "Let us enjoy the benefits of the time." The Romans enjoyed the benefits of their own valor and prudence; time drives everything before it, and is able to bring with it good as well as evil, and evil as well as good.

But let us return to France and inquire whether that country has done any of the things mentioned. I will speak of Louis (and not of Charles¹) as the one whose conduct is worth observing, since he held possession of Italy for the longest period. You will see that he has done the opposite of the things which ought to be done to retain a state composed of diverse elements.

King Louis was brought into Italy through the ambition of the Venetians, who wanted to obtain half the state of Lombardy by his intervention. I will not blame the king for taking this course. Wishing to get a foothold in Italy, and having no friends there—seeing rather that every door was shut to him because of the previous conduct of Charles—he was forced to accept the friendships he could get. He would have succeeded very quickly in his design if he had not made some mistakes in other matters. Having acquired Lombardy, Louis regained at once the authority which Charles had lost. Genoa yielded; the Florentines became his friends; the Marquess of Mantua, the Duke of Ferrara, the Bentivogli, my lady of Forli, the Lords of Faenza, of Pesaro, of Rimini, of Camerino, of Piombino, the Lucchese, the Pisans, Sienese—everybody looked to become his friend. Then the Venetians were able to realize the rashness of the course they had taken: in order for them to secure two towns in Lombardy, they had made the king master of two-thirds of Italy.

Let us now consider how, with little difficulty, the king could have maintained his position in Italy if he had observed the rules laid out above and kept all his friends

secure and protected. Although his friends were numerous, they were both weak and timid, some afraid of the Church, some of the Venetians. Thus, they would always have been forced to stand in with him, and with their help he could easily have made himself secure against those who remained powerful. But no sooner was he in Milan than he did the contrary by assisting Pope Alexander to occupy the Romagna. It never occurred to him that by taking this action he was weakening himself, depriving himself of friends and of those who had thrown themselves into his lap, while at the same time adding much worldly power to the spiritual power of the Church, thus giving it greater authority. Having committed this primary error, he was obliged to follow through; to put an end to Alexander's ambition and prevent him from becoming the master of Tuscany, Louis was forced to come to Italy himself.

And as if it were not enough to have strengthened the Church and deprived himself of allies, he now made a further mistake. Wishing to have the kingdom of Naples, he divided it with the King of Spain. Where he had been the sole leader in Italy, he now had an associate, giving the ambitious of that country and the malcontents of his own someone to provide shelter. Louis could have left a king in Naples who was willing to act on his behalf, but instead he displaced that king to make room for another who, in turn, was able to drive Louis from the kingdom.

To be sure, the wish to acquire more is natural and common, and people want to do so when they can. For this they should be praised and not blamed; it is only when they cannot do so, yet wish to do so by any means, that there is folly and blame. Therefore, if Louis could have attacked Naples with his own forces, then he ought to have done so; if he could not, then he ought not to have divided it. While the partition he made with the Venetians in Lombardy was justified because it gave him a foothold in Italy, the partition in Naples merited blame because it did not have the same excuse of necessity.

To sum up, Louis made these five errors: he destroyed the minor powers, he increased the strength of one of the greater powers in Italy, he brought in a foreign power, he did not settle in the country, and he did not send colonists. If he had lived, even these errors would not have been enough to injure him if he had not made a sixth by taking the Venetians' dominions away from them. Had he not already strengthened the Church or brought Spain into Italy, it would have been very reasonable and necessary to humble the Venetians. But having made those earlier mistakes, he

¹ *Charles* Charles VIII, "The Affable," born 1470, King of France from 1483 until his death in 1498.

should never have consented to the Venetians' ruin; so long as the Venetians remained powerful, they would have kept away others with designs on Lombardy. The Venetians would never have permitted a move against Lombardy unless they gained control of it, but no other power would wish to take Lombardy from France in order to give it to the Venetians. And no one would have had the courage to act against both France and Venice.

If anyone argues that King Louis yielded the Romagna to Alexander and the kingdom to Spain to avoid war, I would answer that, for the reasons given above, a blunder ought never to be perpetrated to avoid war. As I have said, war cannot be avoided, but can only be deferred to your disadvantage. Someone else might give the excuse that the king had pledged to the Pope that he would assist him in the enterprise in exchange for the dissolution of his marriage¹ and for the Cardinal's hat to be given to the Archbishop of Rouen.² To that, my reply is what I will write later concerning the faith of princes and how it ought to be kept.

King Louis, therefore, lost Lombardy because he did not follow any of the guidelines that must be observed by those who have taken possession of countries and wish to retain them. There is no miracle about any of this; it is all quite reasonable and natural. I spoke on these matters at Nantes with Rouen, when Valentino—as Cesare Borgia,³ the son of Pope Alexander, was usually called—occupied the Romagna. When Cardinal Rouen observed to me that the Italians did not understand war, I replied that the French did not understand statecraft, meaning that otherwise they would not have allowed the Church to reach such greatness. In fact, as has been seen, France caused the Church and Spain to become great in Italy, and the ruin of France can be attributed to them. From this can be drawn a general rule which never or rarely fails: that one who is the cause of another becoming powerful is ruined. This is because that increase in power must be brought about either by astuteness or by force, and the one who has been raised to power will be distrustful of both.

¹ *his marriage* Louis XII divorced his wife, Jeanne, daughter of Louis XI, and married in 1499 Anne of Brittany, widow of Charles VIII, in order to retain the Duchy of Brittany for the crown.

² *Archbishop of Rouen* Georges d'Amboise (1460–1510), created a cardinal by Alexander VI.

³ *Cesare Borgia* Italian military leader (c. 1475–1507), illegitimate son of Pope Alexander VI, and cardinal. He was commander of the papal armies, with a reputation for cruelty, opportunistic ruthlessness, and treachery.

Chapter 4: Why the kingdom of Darius, conquered by Alexander, did not rebel against the successors of Alexander at his death

Considering all the difficulties associated with holding on to a newly acquired state, some might wonder why, when Alexander the Great became the master of Asia in a few years and died when it was barely settled, the whole empire did not rebel. Nothing of that sort occurred: his successors maintained their positions, and they had to face no difficulty other than that which arose among themselves from their own ambitions.

To those who think this strange, I point out that all known principalities are governed in one of two different ways. One way is for a prince to rule over his subjects with the assistance of some people he permits to assist him as ministers. The other way is for the principality to be governed by a prince with barons, who hold that rank according to heredity and not by the grace of the prince. Such barons have states with their own subjects, who recognize them as lords and have natural affection for them. Those states that are governed by a prince and his servants hold their prince in higher esteem, since in all the country there is no one who is recognized as similarly powerful. If they give their obedience to another, they give it as to a minister and official, and do not bear any particular affection for him.

In our time, these two kinds of government are exemplified by the Turkish Empire and France. The entire monarchy of the Turks is governed by one lord, and the others are his servants; dividing his kingdom into sanjaks, he sends different administrators to them, and shifts and changes them as he chooses. But the King of France is placed in the midst of an ancient body of lords, who are acknowledged by their own subjects, and beloved by them. The lords have their own powers and privileges, and the king cannot take these away except at his peril. One who considers both of these states will recognize that there are great difficulties in seizing the Turkish state, but that, once it is conquered, there will be great ease in holding it. The difficulties in seizing the Turkish kingdom arise because the usurper cannot be brought in by the princes of the kingdom, nor can he hope to be assisted in his designs by the revolt of those who the lord keeps close to him. This is for the reasons given above; the lord's ministers, being all slaves and bound to

him, can only be corrupted with great difficulty. Even when they have been corrupted, one can expect little advantage from them, as they cannot carry the people with them, for the reasons explained above. Hence, one who attacks the Turks must bear in mind that he will find them united, and he will have to rely on his own strength, without counting on any discontent among the enemy. But once the lord has been conquered and thoroughly defeated in the field so that he cannot replace his armies, there is nothing to fear but his family. Once they are exterminated, there remains no one to fear, since the others have no credit with the people; as the conqueror did not rely on them before his victory, so he ought not to fear them after it.

The contrary happens in kingdoms governed like France. One can easily enter there by winning over some baron of the kingdom, because one can always find malcontents and people who desire change. Such barons, for the reasons given, can open the way into the state and provide an easy victory; but if you wish to hold the state afterwards, you meet with infinite difficulties, both from those you have assisted and from those you have crushed. And it is not enough for you to have defeated the family of the prince, because the lords that remain make themselves the heads of fresh movements against you. You will be unable either to satisfy or to exterminate them, and they will take the state from you whenever time presents the opportunity.

Now, if you will consider the nature of the government of Darius, you will find it similar to that of the Turkish kingdom. All that was necessary was for Alexander first to overthrow Darius in the field, and then to take the country from him. After this victory, Darius being killed, the state remained securely in Alexander's possession for the above reasons. If his successors had been united, they would have enjoyed it securely and at their ease, for there were no upheavals created in the kingdom except those they provoked themselves.

But it is impossible to hold so easily states constituted in the way that France is—with powerful barons as well as kings. Hence arose frequent rebellions against the Romans in Spain, France, and Greece, owing to the many principalities there were in these states. As long as the memory of the principalities endured, the Romans held these states as insecure possessions, but once they had ruled for a long time and the memory of the principalities had passed away, the Romans then became secure possessors. When, later, the Romans were fighting amongst themselves, each one was able to attach himself to his own parts of the country

according to the authority he had assumed there; the family of the former lord being long exterminated, none other than the Romans were acknowledged.

Bearing these things in mind, no one will marvel at the ease with which Alexander held the Empire of Asia, or at the difficulties which others, such as Pyrrhus and many like him, have faced in trying to keep an acquisition. These differences are not brought about by a lack of or abundance of ability in the conquerors, but by the absence of uniformity in subject states.

Chapter 5: Concerning the way to govern cities or principalities which lived under their own laws before they were annexed

Whenever states in which people are accustomed to living in freedom under their laws have been acquired as I have described above, there are three courses of action open to those who wish to hold on to them. The first is to ruin them; the next is to reside there in person; the third is to permit the people to live under their own laws, while at the same time exacting from them a tribute,¹ and establishing within the state an oligarchy which will keep it friendly to you. An oligarchical government created by the prince will know that it cannot last without his friendship and interest, and will do its utmost to support him. The ruler who wants to win over a city that is accustomed to freedom will do so more easily by means of its own citizens than in any other way. But establishing an oligarchical government may not be the most reliable approach. Take, for example, the Spartans and the Romans. The Spartans held Athens and Thebes by establishing an oligarchy, but lost both cities. The Romans, in order to hold Capua, Carthage, and Numantia, dismantled them, and did not lose them. They wished to hold Greece as the Spartans had held it, making it free and allowing it to have its laws, and did not succeed. So to hold the region they were compelled to destroy many cities within it, for in truth there is no sure way to retain control of such cities except by ruining them. When a city is accustomed to freedom, he who becomes master of it and does not destroy it runs the risk of being destroyed by it; for the city can always find two rallying points for rebellion: the cause of liberty itself and the cause of maintaining its ancient privileges, which

¹ tribute Tax.

neither time nor new privileges will ever make it forget. Whatever you may do, unless the people are disunited or dispersed, they will never forget the cause of liberty and of those privileges; at every chance they will immediately rally to that cause, as Pisa did after the hundred years she had been held in bondage by the Florentines.

When cities or countries have been accustomed to live under a prince, on the one hand, things are likely to be quite different. If, for example, a prince and his family are exterminated, the people are likely to be uncertain how to react. Being accustomed to obeying a prince but lacking any price to obey, they will not be able to agree on choosing a new prince from amongst themselves, and they will not know how to govern themselves. For this reason they are very slow to take up arms, and a prince can win them over and establish himself much more securely. In republics there is more vitality, greater hatred, and a greater desire for vengeance in such circumstances; republics will never permit the memory of their former liberty to rest; so the safest way is to destroy them or to reside there.

Chapter 6: Concerning new principalities which are acquired through one's own arms and ability

No one should be surprised if, in speaking of entirely new principalities as I shall do, I cite the greatest examples both of prince and of state. Men almost always walk along paths beaten by others and imitate their deeds, although for the most part they are still unable entirely to walk in the path of others or attain to the power of those they imitate. A wise man ought always to follow the paths beaten by great men, and to imitate those who have been supreme, so that if his ability does not equal theirs, at least it will have the tinge of it. Let him act like those prudent archers who, trying to hit the mark which yet appears too far distant, and knowing the limits of the strength of their bow, take aim much higher than the mark, not in order to shoot their arrow to so great a height, but rather, by aiming so high, to hit the mark they wish to reach.

I say, therefore, that in entirely new principalities, where there is a new prince, the likelihood of his remaining in power will depend on whether the new prince displays greater or lesser ability. Now, since a private citizen who becomes a prince must have had either ability or fortune, it is clear that one or other of these two things will mitigate

many difficulties to some degree. Nevertheless, he who has relied least on fortune is the best. Further, it facilitates matters when the prince, having no other state to govern, is compelled to reside there in person.

But let us turn to those who have risen to become princes by their own ability and not through fortune. I say that Moses, Cyrus, Romulus, Theseus,¹ and such like are the most excellent examples. Perhaps we should really not include Moses, since he was a mere executor of the will of God, yet he ought to be admired, if only for the grace that made him worthy to speak with God. But Cyrus and others who have acquired or founded kingdoms are all admirable; and if we consider their particular deeds and methods, we will find them to be not inferior to those of Moses, although he had so great a teacher. And if we examine their actions and lives we can see that they owed nothing to fortune except opportunity, which gave them the material to mould into the form which seemed best to them. Without that opportunity their strength of spirit would have been extinguished; but without their strength of spirit the opportunity would have come in vain.

It was therefore necessary for Moses to find the people of Israel in Egypt enslaved and oppressed by the Egyptians, in order that they should be disposed to follow him and be delivered out of bondage. It was necessary that Romulus should not remain in Alba, and that he should be abandoned at birth, in order that he should become King of Rome and founder of the nation. It was necessary that Cyrus should find the Persians discontented with the government of the Medes, and the Medes soft and effeminate as a result of their long peace. Theseus could not have shown his ability had he not found the Athenians dispersed. These opportunities made those men fortunate, and their high ability enabled them to recognize the opportunity through which they could enable their country and make it fortunate.

Those, like these men, who through their courage become princes acquire a principality² with difficulty, but they keep it with ease. The difficulties they have in acquiring it

¹ *Moses* The Old Testament religious and military leader of the Jews, who led his people out of slavery in Egypt; *Cyrus* Cyrus the Great was the sixth-century BCE founder of the Persian Empire; *Romulus* According to tradition, Romulus, together with his brother Remus, founded Rome in the eighth century BCE and was its first king, conquering and annexing a large territory; *Theseus* Legendary founder of Athens and hero of Greek mythology.

² *principality* Position held by a prince.

arise in part from the new rules and methods which they are forced to introduce to establish their government and its security. And it ought to be remembered that there is nothing more difficult to execute, more perilous to conduct, or more uncertain in its success, than taking the lead in the introduction of a new political order. For the innovator has for enemies all those who have done well under the old conditions, and lukewarm defenders in those who may do well under the new. This coolness arises partly from fear of opponents, who have the laws on their side, and partly from the incredulity of men, who do not readily believe in new things until they have had a long experience of them. Thus it happens that whenever those who are hostile have the opportunity to attack, they do it with the zeal of partisans, while the others defend lukewarmly. As a result the prince is endangered along with them.

If we desire to discuss this matter thoroughly, then we must inquire whether these innovators can rely on themselves or have to depend on others. To achieve their goal, do they have to beg for help or can they use force in carrying out their plans? If the first, they always fare badly, and never accomplish anything; but when they can rely on themselves and use force, then they are rarely endangered. Hence it is that all armed prophets have conquered, and the unarmed ones have been destroyed. Besides the reasons mentioned, the nature of the people is variable, and while it is easy to persuade them, it is difficult to keep them convinced. And thus it is necessary to take such measures that, when they believe no longer, they can be made to believe by force.

If Moses, Cyrus, Theseus, and Romulus had been unarmed, they could not have enforced their constitutions for long—as happened in our time to Fra Girolamo Savonarola.¹ Both Savonarola and the new institutions he had created were ruined when the multitude came to believe in him no longer, and he had no means either of keeping steadfast those who believed or of making the unbelievers believe. As we can see, then, such men have great difficulties and dangers in achieving their goals. But when these are overcome, and those who have envied them their success are exterminated, they will begin to be respected, and they will continue afterwards powerful, secure, honored, and happy.

To these great examples I wish to add one more—that of Hiero of Syracuse.² He is a less important figure than those mentioned above, but his case bears some resemblance to theirs, and may serve as an example of circumstances common to many others. This man rose from a private position to be Prince of Syracuse. He owed nothing to Fortune, everything to opportunity; the Syracusans, being oppressed, chose him as their captain. Afterwards they rewarded him by making him their prince. He was of such great ability, even as a private citizen, that according to one source he lacked nothing but a kingdom to be a king.³ This man abolished the old army, organized a new one, gave up old alliances, made new ones. Since he had his own soldiers and allies, he had strong foundations on which to build any edifice: thus, while he had endured much trouble in acquiring his position, he had little in keeping it.

Chapter 7: Concerning new principalities which are acquired either through the arms of others or by good fortune

Those private citizens who rise to become princes solely as a result of good fortune have little trouble rising, but much trouble remaining on top; they have no difficulty on the way up, since they fly up, but they have many difficulties when they reach the summit. Of this sort are those to whom a principality is given either in exchange for money or else through the favor of him who bestows it. Such things took place in Greece, in the cities of Ionia and of the Hellespont, where princes were installed by Darius⁴ to hold the cities both for his security and for his glory. Private citizens who become emperors through the corruption of soldiers are in a similar category. In this sort of situation, everything depends for the rulers on the good will and the fortune of those who have elevated them—two most inconstant and unstable things. They are not likely to have the knowledge required for the position, since, unless they are men of great worth and ability, it is not reasonable to expect that people who have always lived in private rather than public life should know how to command. Moreover, they cannot

¹ *Fra Girolamo Savonarola* Italian priest and political leader of Florence (1452–98), known for his agitation for religious reform and his opposition to Renaissance culture (as a burner of books and destroyer of paintings). He drove the Medici out of Florence and was eventually excommunicated, tortured, and executed for criticizing the Pope.

² *Hiero of Syracuse* Hiero II (307–216 BCE) was so successful as an army commander that he was elected king of Syracuse.

³ *he lacked nothing ... to be a king* Inaccurate quotation from the Roman historian Justin.

⁴ *Darius* Last king of Persia who reigned from 336 to 331 BCE.

be sure of holding their position because they do not have forces which they can keep friendly and faithful to them.

States that rise unexpectedly, then, like all other things in nature which are born and grow rapidly, cannot have foundations stable enough to endure the first storm; unless, as I noted, those who unexpectedly become princes are men of so much ability that they know they have to be prepared both to hold onto that which fortune has thrown into their laps, and afterwards to lay the sort of foundation that others have laid before they became princes.

Let me now cite examples of these two methods of rising to be a prince—through ability or through fortune. These two examples are within our own recollection: Francesco Sforza and Cesare Borgia. Francesco, by proper means and with great ability, rose from his position as a private person to become Duke of Milan. He kept the post, which he had acquired with a thousand anxieties, with little trouble. On the other hand, Cesare Borgia, called by the people Duke Valentino, acquired his state during the ascendancy of his father, and on its decline he lost it, notwithstanding that he had taken every measure and done all that ought to be done by a wise and able man to firmly fix his roots in those states which the arms and fortunes of others had bestowed on him.

For, as I stated above, he who has not first laid his foundations may be able if he possesses great ability to lay them afterwards, but in that case they will be laid with trouble to the architect and danger to the building. The Duke Valentino is one who laid solid foundations for his future power, and I do not consider it superfluous to discuss them, because I do not know what better precepts to give a new prince than the example of Valentino's actions. If his efforts were finally to no avail, that was not his fault, but the extraordinary and extreme malignity of fortune.¹

Alexander VI,² in attempting to advance his son the duke, faced many difficulties. Firstly, he did not see any way in which he could put his son in charge of any state that was not a state of the Church; and if he was willing to try to take a state away from Church control, he knew that the Duke of Milan and the Venetians would not consent, because Faenza and Rimini were already under the protection of the Venetians. Besides this, he saw that the armed forces of Italy, especially those which he might have used, were controlled by those who would fear the greatness of

the Pope, namely, the Orsini and the Colonna³ and their following. It was advantageous to him, therefore, to upset this state of affairs and create turmoil for these powers, so as to safely obtain control of part of their states. This was easy for him to do, because the Venetians wanted for their own reasons to bring back the French into Italy; he would not only not oppose this, but he would render it easier by dissolving the former marriage of King Louis. Therefore the king came into Italy with the assistance of the Venetians and the consent of Alexander. He was no sooner in Milan than the Pope obtained soldiers from him for the Romagna campaign; this was made possible because of the prestige of the king. The duke, having acquired the Romagna and beaten the Colonna, then wished to hold the Romagna and to advance further, but he was hindered by two things. First, a suspicion that his forces were not loyal to him; and second, the will of the King of France. That is to say, he feared that the forces of the Orsini, which he was using, would not stand with him—that they might hinder him from winning more, but also that they might themselves seize what he had won, and that the King might also do the same. He had experienced this with the Orsini when, after taking Faenza and attacking Bologna, he saw them go only reluctantly to battle. And he learned the king's intentions when he himself, after taking the duchy of Urbino, attacked Tuscany, and the king made him desist from that undertaking; hence the duke decided to depend no more upon the troops and fortunes of others.

First he weakened the Orsini and Colonna parties in Rome, by winning over to himself all their adherents who were gentlemen, making them *his* gentlemen, giving them good pay, and, according to their rank, honoring them with office and command in such a way that in a few months all attachment to their factions was destroyed and turned entirely to the duke. After this he awaited an opportunity to crush the Orsini, having scattered the adherents of the Colonna. This came to him soon and he used it well; the Orsini, realizing too late that the greatness of the duke and the Church would ruin them, called a meeting at Magione, in the territory of Perugia. From this sprung the rebellion at Urbino and the insurrections in the Romagna, with endless dangers to the duke, all of which he overcame with the help of the French. His authority was restored;

1 *malignity of fortune* As described below, this is his illness after the death of his father.

2 *Alexander VI* Rodrigo Borgia (1431–1503); Pope from 1492 until his death.

3 *the Orsini and the Colonna* Powerful Roman families who played important roles in Italian history. They were hereditary enemies with a rivalry that lasted until the *Pax Romana* of 1511.

and in order not to risk it by trusting either the French or other outside forces, he had turned to strategic deception. He knew very well how to conceal his aims and used as an intermediary Signor Paolo [Orsini]—whom the duke did not fail to secure with all kinds of attention, giving him money, garments, and horses. With Signor Paolo's help, the Orsini were reconciled, so that their stupidity brought them into the duke's power at Sinigaglia. Having exterminated the leaders, and turned their partisans into his friends, the duke had laid sufficiently good foundations for exercising his power; he had control of all the Romagna and of the duchy of Urbino; and he won the support of the people, who had begun to appreciate their prosperity. (And as this last point is worthy of notice, and to be imitated by others, I am not willing to leave it out.)

When the duke occupied the Romagna he found it under the rule of weak masters, who plundered their subjects rather than governed them, and gave them more cause for disunion than for union; so that the country was full of robbery, quarrels, and every kind of violence. Wishing to bring back peace and obedience to authority, the duke considered it necessary to appoint a good governor. He promoted Ramiro d'Orco [de Lorqua], an unscrupulous and cruel man, to whom he gave the fullest power. This man in a short time restored peace and had great success in establishing unity. But afterwards the duke considered that it would not be advisable to confer such excessive authority on him on an ongoing basis, for the duke was sure that Ramiro would become odious. He therefore set up a court of judgment in the country, under a most excellent president, wherein all cities had their advocates. And because the duke knew that the severity of his past behavior had caused some hatred against himself, he desired to clear himself in the minds of the people and win them over to his side. He wanted to show them, indeed, that, if any cruelty had been perpetrated, it had not originated with him, but in the violent nature of Ramiro his minister. Under this pretence he had Ramiro arrested and then one morning had him executed and left on the piazza at Cesena, with the block and a bloody knife at his side. The barbarity of this spectacle caused the people to be satisfied and dismayed at the same time.

But let us return to where we left off. The duke now found himself in a powerful position. He had largely secured himself against immediate dangers by having armed himself in his own way, and by having in great measure crushed those forces in his vicinity that could injure him.

He had next to consider France, for he knew that the king, who had become aware of his mistake too late, would not support him. And from this time the duke began to seek new alliances and to vacillate with France in the expedition which she was making towards the kingdom of Naples against the Spaniards who were besieging Gaeta. It was the duke's intention to secure himself against them, and he would have quickly accomplished this had Alexander lived.

These were the actions he undertook with a view to the present. As to the future, he had to fear, in the first place, that a new successor to the Church might not be friendly to him and might seek to take from him that which Alexander had given him. So he decided to act in four ways. First, he decided to exterminate the families of those lords whom he had despoiled, so as to take away that opportunity from the Pope. Second, he took it upon himself to win over all the gentlemen of Rome, so as to be able to resist the Pope with their aid, as I have mentioned. Third, he worked at converting the College of Cardinals¹ to his side. Fourth, he endeavored to acquire such a large territory before the Pope died that he could resist the first attack on his own. When Alexander died,² he had accomplished three of these four things. He had killed as many of the dispossessed lords as he could lay hands on, and few had escaped; he had won over the Roman gentlemen, and he had the most numerous party in the College of Cardinals. And as to any fresh acquisition, he intended to become master of Tuscany, for he already possessed Perugia and Piombino, and Pisa was under his protection. And since he did not have to pay attention to France any longer (for the French had already been driven out of the kingdom of Naples by the Spaniards, and in this way both were compelled to buy his good will), he pounced on Pisa. After this, Lucca and Siena yielded at once, partly through hatred and partly through fear of the Florentines; and the Florentines would have had no remedy had he continued to prosper, as he was prospering the year that Alexander died, for he had acquired so much power and reputation that he would have stood by himself, and no longer have depended on the luck and the forces of others, but solely on his own power and ability.

But Alexander died five years after he had first drawn the sword. He left the duke with only the state of Romagna consolidated. The rest was in the air, hanging in the balance between two powerful hostile armies, while the duke

¹ *College of Cardinals* Body that elects the Pope.

² *Alexander died* Alexander VI died in 1503.

himself lay gravely ill. The duke possessed such boldness and ability and knew so well how men are to be won or lost, and had laid down such firm foundations in so short a time, that if he had not had those armies on his back, or if he had been in good health, he would have overcome all difficulties. And it is clear that his foundations were good, for the Romagna awaited him for more than a month. In Rome, although but half alive, he remained secure; though the Baglioni, the Vitelli, and the Orsini came to Rome, they could not accomplish anything against him. Perhaps he could not choose the one he wanted to be Pope, but at least it should have been possible to prevent the one whom he did not want from being elected. If he had been in sound health at the death of Alexander, everything would have been easy for him—but instead he lay deathly ill. On the day that Julius II was elected, he told me that he had thought of everything that might occur at the death of his father, and had provided a remedy for every circumstance, except that he had never anticipated that at the time of his father's death, he would be at the edge of death himself.

When all the actions of the duke are recalled, I do not know how to reproach him. Rather it appears to me, as I have said, that I ought to propose that he be imitated by all those who, through fortune or the troops of others, are raised to government. The duke, having a lofty spirit and far-reaching aims, could not have conducted himself otherwise or achieved greater results; only the shortness of the life of Alexander and his own sickness frustrated his designs. He who considers it necessary to secure himself in his new principality; to win friends; to overcome enemies either by force or fraud; to make himself beloved and feared by the people; to be followed and revered by the soldiers; to exterminate those who have power or reason to hurt him; to change the old order of things for a new one; to be severe and gracious, magnanimous and generous; to destroy a disloyal army and to create a new one; to maintain friendship with kings and princes in such a way that they will help him enthusiastically and will be careful not to offend him; he who desires all this cannot find a better example to follow than the actions of this man.

The duke can be blamed only for the election of Julius II, in whom he made a bad choice. Although it has been said he was not able to elect the Pope he preferred, he could have prevented any other from being elected Pope; and he ought never to have consented to the election of a cardinal whom he had injured or who had cause to fear him if they became pope. For men injure either from fear or hatred.

He had injured, among others, San Pietro ad Vincula, Colonna, San Giorgio, and Ascanio.¹ Any one of the others, on becoming Pope, would have had to fear him, except Rouen² and the Spaniards; the latter from their relationship and obligations, the former from his influence (the kingdom of France having relations with him). Therefore, above all, the duke ought to have created a Spaniard Pope, and, failing him, he ought to have consented to Rouen and not San Pietro ad Vincula. He who believes that new benefits will cause great personages to forget old injuries is deceived. In this case, the duke erred in his choice, and it was the cause of his ultimate ruin.

Chapter 8: Concerning those who have obtained a principality through wickedness

I have spoken of certain methods whereby an ordinary citizen may become a prince—methods that are not entirely matters of fortune or virtue. There are two other methods of which I should say something here (I will also discuss one of them at greater length elsewhere, in discussing republics). The first of these occurs when a private citizen becomes prince through some wicked or nefarious ways, the second when a private citizen becomes prince through the favor of his fellow-citizens. I will illustrate the first of those by two examples—one ancient, the other modern—and not enter further into the subject. I consider these two examples will be enough for those who may be compelled to follow them.

Agathocles,³ the Sicilian, rose to become King of Syracuse not from the position of an ordinary citizen but from a low and abject position. This man, the son of a potter, led a life of wickedness through a series of changes in his fortunes. But he accompanied his wickedness with so much ability of mind and body that, having devoted himself to the military profession, he rose through its ranks to be Praetor⁴ of Syracuse. Once established in that position, he deliberately resolved to make himself prince and to hold on

¹ *San Pietro ad Vincula* Julius II had been Cardinal of San Pietro ad Vincula; *San Giorgio* Raffaels Riaxis; *Ascanio* Cardinal Ascanio Sforza.

² *Rouen* Georges d'Amboise.

³ *Agathocles* King of Syracuse (317–289 BCE) and of Sicily (304–289 BCE).

⁴ *Praetor* Chief law officer of the state—second in rank only to Consul.

by violence to the position which had been given to him by universal consent, paying no attention to his obligations to others.¹ For this purpose he reached an agreement with Hamilcar,² the Carthaginian, who, with his army, was fighting in Sicily. One morning he assembled the people and senate of Syracuse, as if he had to discuss with them matters relating to the Republic, and at a given signal the soldiers killed all the senators and the richest citizens; with them dead, he seized and held the principedom of that city without any opposition from the citizens. And although he was twice defeated by the Carthaginians, and later besieged, not only was he able to defend his city, but leaving part of his men for its defense, he was able to use the rest of his men to attack Africa, and in a short time to free Syracuse. The Carthaginians, in a desperate state, were compelled to come to terms with Agathocles, and, leaving Sicily to him, had to be content with the possession of Africa.³

No one who considers the actions and the genius of this man will see anything (or at most a very little) which can be attributed to fortune; Agathocles attained pre-eminence, as is shown above, not by anyone's favor, but step by step in the military profession. He made each step accompanied by a thousand troubles and perils; and afterwards he maintained his position by courageous and dangerous means. Yet it cannot be called virtue to slay fellow-citizens, to deceive friends, to be without faith, without mercy, without religion; such methods may gain empire, but not glory. Still, if the courage of Agathocles in entering into and extricating himself from dangers be considered, together with his greatness of mind in enduring overcoming hardships, it does not seem that he should be esteemed less than the most notable captain. Nevertheless, his barbarous cruelty, his inhumanity, and his many wicked deeds do not allow him to be celebrated among the most excellent men. What he achieved cannot be attributed either to fortune or to virtue.

In our times, during the rule of Alexander VI, Oliverotto da Fermo, having been left an orphan many years before, was brought up by his maternal uncle, Giovanni Fogliani, and in the early days of his youth was sent to be a soldier under

Paolo Vitelli. The idea was that, after being trained under Paolo's discipline, Oliverotto might attain some high position in the military profession. After Paolo died, Oliverotto fought under his brother Vitellozzo, and in a very short time, being endowed with skill and a vigorous body and mind, he became a leader of troops. But since it appeared to him a paltry thing to serve under others, he resolved to seize Fermo, aided by some citizens of Fermo (who evidently preferred the slavery of their country to its liberty), as well as by the Vitelli. So he wrote to Giovanni Fogliani that, having been away from home for many years, he wished to visit him and his city, and to look into the matter of his inheritance. He said that, although he had not labored to acquire anything except honor, yet, in order that the citizens should see he had not spent his time in vain, he desired to come honorably, and so would be accompanied by one hundred horsemen, his friends, and retainers. He begged Giovanni to arrange that he should be received honorably by the citizens of Fermo, which would be not only to his honor, but also to that of Giovanni himself, who had raised him.

Giovanni did not fail in any duty toward his nephew; he had him received honorably by the Fermoans, and he lodged him in his own house, where, having passed some days, and having arranged what was necessary for his wicked designs, Oliverotto gave a solemn banquet to which he invited Giovanni Fogliani and the chiefs of Fermo. When the meal and all the entertainment that is usual at such banquets were finished, Oliverotto artfully began certain grave discourses, speaking of the greatness of Pope Alexander and his son Cesare, and of their undertakings. After Giovanni and others replied, he suddenly arose, saying that such matters ought to be discussed in a more private place, and he withdrew to a private room. Giovanni and the rest of the citizens followed him. No sooner were they seated than soldiers emerged from hiding and slaughtered Giovanni and the others. After these murders Oliverotto, mounted on horseback, rode up and down the town and besieged the chief officials in the palace, so that the people were forced to obey him out of fear, and to form a government, of which he made himself the prince. He killed all those who might be able to harm him, and strengthened himself with new civil and military ordinances, in such a way that, in the year during which he held the principality, not only was he secure in the city of Fermo, but he had become formidable to all his neighbors. To destroy him would have been as difficult in the case of Agathocles if only Oliverotto had not allowed himself to be deceived by Cesare Borgia, who killed

1 *universal consent ... obligations to others* He could have become prince by consent of the Senate, but chose not to, because that would have created obligations to them.

2 *Hamilcar* Statesman (c. 270–228 BCE) and Carthaginian general during the First Punic War.

3 *Africa* In this case, "Africa" means the region surrounding Carthage in North Africa, on the south shore of the Mediterranean Sea.

him along with the Orsini and Vitelli at Sinigaglia, as was stated above. Thus, one year after he had committed this parricide, he was strangled, together with Vitellozzo, whom he had made his teacher in virtue and wickedness.

Some may wonder how it can happen that Agathocles, and his like, after infinite treacheries and cruelties, are able to live for so long secure in their own country, and are able to defend themselves from external enemies and never be conspired against by their own citizens. After all, many others have never been able to hold the state by means of cruelty even in peaceful times, still less in the uncertain times of war. I believe that this all depends on whether cruelty is badly or properly used. Cruel measures are properly used—if one might speak well of evil—when they are applied a single time, are necessary to one's security, and are not persisted in afterwards unless they can be turned to the advantage of the subjects. Cruel measures badly employed are those which, despite being few at the beginning, multiply with time rather than decrease. Those who practice the first system are able, by aid of God or man, to remedy their condition to some degree, as Agathocles did. It is impossible for those who follow the other system to maintain their position.

We should therefore note that, in seizing a state, the usurper ought to consider carefully which injuries it is necessary for him to inflict, and to do them all at one stroke so as not to have to repeat them daily. By not unduly unsettling men he will be able to reassure them, and win them to himself by offering them benefits. He who does otherwise, either from timidity or evil advice, is always compelled to keep the knife in his hand. He cannot rely on his subjects, and nor can they attach themselves to him, owing to their continued and repeated injuries. As a general rule, then, injuries ought to be inflicted all at one time, so that, being tasted less, they offend less; benefits ought to be given little by little, so that the flavor of them may last longer.

Above all, a prince ought to live among his people in such a way that no unexpected circumstances, whether good or evil, shall make him change; because if the necessity for this comes in troubled times, it will be too late to take harsh measures; and mild ones will not help you, for they will be seen to be forced from you, and no one will owe you any gratitude for them.

Chapter 9: Concerning a civil principality

But now let us consider the second case—where a leading citizen becomes the prince of his country, not by wickedness or any intolerable violence, but by the favor of his fellow citizens. This sort of rule may be called a civil principality; neither genius nor fortune is necessary to achieve this, but rather fortunate astuteness. I believe that such a principality is obtained either by the favor of the people or by the favor of the nobles. These two distinct parties are found in all cities. The people do not wish to be ruled or oppressed by the nobles, but the nobles wish to rule and oppress the people; and from these two opposite desires may arise in cities one of three results: a principality, self-government, or anarchy.

A principality is created either by the people or by the nobles, depending on which of the two groups has the opportunity. The nobles, seeing they cannot withstand the people, begin to support one of themselves, and they try to make him a prince, so that under his shadow they can satisfy their ambitions. The people, finding they cannot resist the nobles, also support one of themselves, and try to make him a prince so as to be defended by his authority. He who obtains sovereignty by the assistance of the nobles maintains himself with more difficulty than he who comes to it by the aid of the people, because the former finds himself with many around him who consider themselves his equals; because of this he can neither rule nor manage them as he likes. But he who reaches sovereignty by popular favor finds himself alone, and has none around him, or few, who are not prepared to obey him.

Moreover, it is impossible to satisfy the nobles by fair dealing, and without causing injury to others, but you can satisfy the people, for their object is more righteous than that of the nobles; the nobles wish to oppress, while the people desire only not to be oppressed. It is to be added also that a prince can never make himself secure against a hostile people, because they are too many, while he can secure himself from the nobles, as they are few in number. The worst that a prince may expect from a hostile people is to be abandoned by them; whereas from hostile nobles he has to fear not only abandonment, but also that they will rise against him. (Nobles, being in these affairs more far-seeing and astute than common people, always come forward in time to save themselves, and to obtain favors from him whom they expect to prevail.) Further, the prince

is compelled to live always with the same people, but he can do well without the same nobles, being able to make and unmake them daily, and to give or take away their authority when it pleases him.

To make this point clearer, let me say that the nobles ought to be looked at mainly in two ways: they either commit themselves to your cause entirely, or they do not. Those who so commit themselves, and are not greedy and grasping, ought to be honored and loved; those who do not commit themselves may be dealt with in two ways. First, regarding those who fail to do this through weak-spirited cowardice and a natural lack of courage, you ought to make use of them, especially those who are good advisors; in prosperous times such people will bring you honor, but in adverse times you need not fear them. Second, regarding those who refuse to commit themselves because they are motivated by their own ambitious aims, this shows that they are giving more thought to themselves than to you. A prince ought to guard against this, and to fear them as if they were open enemies, because in adverse times they will always help to ruin him.

One who becomes a prince through the favor of the people ought to keep them friendly, and this he can easily do since they ask only not to be oppressed by him. But one who, in opposition to the people, becomes a prince by the favor of the nobles, ought, above everything, to seek to win the people over to himself; this he may do easily if he takes them under his protection. Because when men receive good from someone from whom they were expecting evil, they are bound more closely to their benefactor; thus the people quickly become more devoted to him than if he had been raised to the principality by their favors. The prince can win their affections in many ways. But as these vary according to the circumstances, one cannot give fixed rules, so I omit them; but, I repeat, it is necessary for a prince to have the people friendly, otherwise he has no security in adverse times.

Nabis,¹ Prince of the Spartans, withstood the attack of all Greece, and of one of Rome's most victorious armies, and defended his country and his government; to overcome this peril it was only necessary for him to secure himself against a few, but this would not have been sufficient if the people had been hostile. And do not let any one cast doubt on this state-

ment with the trite proverb "He who builds on the people, builds on the mud." This is true when a private citizen makes a foundation there, and persuades himself that the people will free him when he is oppressed by his enemies or by the magistrates. In this he would find himself very often deceived, as happened to the Gracchi² in Rome and to Giorgio Scali³ in Florence. But in the case of a prince who can command, and is a man of courage, undismayed in adversity, who does not fail in other qualifications, and who, by his resolution and energy, keeps up the spirit of the people—such a leader will never find himself deceived by them, and it will be shown that he has laid his foundations well.

These principalities are put in danger when they are passing from the civil to the absolute order of government, for such princes either rule personally or through magistrates. In the latter case their government is weaker and more insecure, because it rests entirely on the good will of those citizens who are appointed as magistrates, and who, especially in troubled times, can destroy the government with great ease, either by intrigue or open defiance. The prince cannot exercise absolute authority under tumultuous conditions, because the citizens and subjects, accustomed to receive orders from magistrates, are not inclined to obey him amid these confusions, and in difficult times there will always be a scarcity of men whom he can trust. Such a prince cannot rely upon what he observes in quiet times, when citizens had need of the state, because then everyone agrees with him, everyone makes promises, and when death is far distant they are all willing to die for him. But in troubled times, when the state has need of its citizens, then he finds but few. And this experiment is very dangerous, inasmuch as it can only be tried once. Therefore a wise prince ought to adopt a course of action that will ensure that his citizens will always need the state and him, in every kind of circumstance. Then he will always find them loyal.

1 *Nabis* Regent, then last king of Sparta (207–192 BCE). He was said to have made himself popular with the people through social reform and a redistribution of wealth, but he was also known for his cruelty.

2 *the Gracchi* Brothers Tiberius Sempronius Gracchus, tribune in 133 BCE, and Gaius Sempronius Gracchus, tribune in 123 and 122 BCE. From a less privileged social class, they attempted to achieve reform (including land redistribution) by limiting the size of large landholdings. Both were killed in political riots—Tiberius in 133 BCE, and Gaius in 121 BCE.

3 *Giorgio Scali* According to Machiavelli, Scali's tyrannical magistracy was ended in 1381 when the populace who had supported him turned against him for his "insolence"; at his execution, Machiavelli says, "he blamed himself for having confided too much in a people who were moved and corrupted by every voice, every act, and every suspicion" (*History of Florence*, Book 3, Section 20).

Chapter 10: Concerning the way in which the strength of all principalities ought to be measured

In examining the character of these principalities it is necessary to consider another point: whether a prince has enough power to support himself with his own resources, or whether he needs the assistance of others. Let me make myself quite clear: I count a prince as being able to support himself by his own resources if he can, either by abundance of troops or money, raise a sufficient army to join battle against anyone who comes to attack him. On the other hand, I count a prince as needing others if he cannot face the enemy in the field, but is forced to defend himself by sheltering behind city walls. The first case has been discussed, and I will say more later on. In the second case one can say nothing except to encourage such princes to provision and fortify their towns, and not on any account to defend the countryside. If a prince fortifies his town well, and manages the other concerns of his subjects in the manner I discussed, potential attackers must be very cautious; for men are always adverse to enterprises in which they foresee difficulties, and it cannot seem easy to attack one who has his town well fortified, and is not hated by his people.

The cities of Germany are completely independent; they own only a little country around them; they obey the emperor only when it suits them, and they do not fear the emperor or any other nearby power, because they are fortified in such a way that everyone thinks that it would be tedious and difficult to take them by assault. They have proper moats and walls and sufficient artillery, and they always keep enough food, drink, and fuel for a year in public depots. And beyond this, in order to keep the people quiet without loss to the state, and to support them, they always have the means of providing employment in jobs that are the life and strength of the city. In addition, they hold military exercises in high regard, and have many laws to ensure that they are maintained.

Therefore, a prince who has a strong city, and has not made himself hated, will not be attacked. Or if he is, the attacker will be driven off in disgrace, because things in this world change, and it is almost impossible to sustain a siege for a whole year with an idle army. Someone might object that if people with property outside the city see it burnt, they will not remain patient, and self-interest will make them forget the interests of their prince during a siege. To

this I answer that a powerful and courageous prince will overcome all such difficulties by alternately giving hope to his subjects that the evil will not continue for long, and instilling fear of the cruelty of the enemy, all the while protecting himself skillfully from those subjects who seem to him to be too openly critical.

When the enemy has just arrived in such instances, the enemy will naturally at once burn and ruin the country. At that time the people's spirits are still hot and ready for defense; so there is even less reason for the prince to hesitate. After a time, when spirits have cooled, the damage is already done, the ills are incurred, and there is no longer any remedy. The people are then much more ready to unite with their prince, who appears to have obligations to them now that their houses have been burnt and their possessions ruined in his defense. For it is the nature of men to be bound by the benefits they confer as much as by those they receive. Therefore, if everything is well considered, it will not be difficult for a wise prince to keep the minds of his citizens steadfast from first to last, so long as he does not lack provisions and weapons for defense.

Chapter 11: Concerning ecclesiastical principalities

It only remains now to speak of ecclesiastical principalities. All difficulties relating to these occur prior to getting possession. They are acquired either by the prince's ability or by good fortune, and they can be held without either; for they are sustained by the ordinances of religion, which are so all-powerful, and of such a nature that the principalities may be held no matter how their princes behave and live. These princes alone have states and do not defend them, they have subjects and do not rule them. The states, although unguarded, are not taken from them, and the subjects, although not ruled, do not care; they have neither the desire nor the ability to alienate themselves from the state. Such principalities are the only completely secure and successful ones. But being upheld by powers beyond the understanding of the human mind, I shall speak no more of them; because they are exalted and maintained by God, it would be the act of a presumptuous and rash man to discuss them.

How had it come about that the Church has attained such greatness in temporal power, seeing that Alexander and the earlier Italian powers (not only those who have been called powers, but every baron and lord, even the weakest)

have placed very little value on temporal power? Yet now a king of France trembles before the power of the church, which has been able to drive him from Italy, and to ruin the Venetians. Although this may be very well known, it doesn't seem superfluous to recall it in some detail.

Before Charles, King of France, invaded Italy, this country was under the dominion of the Pope, the Venetians, the King of Naples, the Duke of Milan, and the Florentines. These potentates had two principal anxieties: one, that no foreigner should enter Italy with his armies; the other, that none of the other Italian potentates should seize more territory. The greatest anxiety concerned the Pope and the Venetians. To restrain the Venetians, the union of all the others was necessary, as it was for the defense of Ferrara. To keep the Pope in check they made use of the barons of Rome, who, being divided into two factions, Orsini and Colonna, were constantly quarrelling. They kept the pontificate weak and powerless by standing with arms in their hands right under the eyes of the Pontiff. And although a courageous pope, such as Sixtus [IV],¹ might sometimes arise, neither fortune nor wisdom could rid him of these annoyances. And the short life of a pope is also a cause of weakness; for in ten years (the average reign of a pope) it is difficult for him to reduce the power of one of the factions. If, for example, one pope should almost destroy the Colonna, a new pope who was hostile to the Orsini would emerge and enable the Colonna to grow powerful again, but would still not have time to suppress them. This was the reason why the temporal powers of the pope were little respected in Italy.

But Alexander VI afterwards showed better than any of the other pontiffs throughout history how a pope with both money and arms could prevail. With Duke Valentino² as his instrument, and because of the invasion of the French, he brought about all those things which I have discussed above when describing the actions of the duke. And although he intended to benefit the duke, not the Church, nevertheless what he did contributed to the greatness of the Church, which, after his death and the ruin of the duke, became heir to the benefits of his labors.

Pope Julius came afterwards and found the Church strong. It possessed all the Romagna, the barons of Rome had been reduced to impotence, and various other factions

had been wiped out by Alexander's force. He also found the way open to accumulate money in a manner such as had never been practiced before Alexander's time. Julius pursued these practices, and even improved on them. He intended to gain Bologna, to ruin the Venetians, and to drive the French out of Italy. All of these enterprises prospered for him, and he is even more praiseworthy, inasmuch as he did everything to strengthen the Church rather than any private person. He kept also the Orsini and Colonna factions within the bounds in which he found them. Although they had some intention to disturb things, nevertheless Julius held two things firm: first, the greatness of the church, with which he terrified them; and second, forbidding them to have their own cardinals, since it was these who had caused the disturbances. Whenever these factions have their cardinals they do not remain quiet for long, because cardinals foster factions both within Rome and outside of Rome, and the barons are compelled to support them. Thus the ambitions of church officials give rise to disorder and quarrels among the barons. For these reasons His Holiness Pope Leo³ found the papacy extremely powerful, and it is to be hoped that, as others made it great in arms, he will make it still greater and more venerated by his goodness and his countless other virtues.

Chapter 12: Of the different types of troops and mercenaries

Having discussed the characteristics of principalities that I proposed to talk about at the beginning, and having considered in some degree the causes of their success or failure, and having shown the methods by which many have sought to acquire them and to hold them, it now remains for me to discuss generally the means of offense and defense which each of these principalities can adopt.

We have seen above how necessary it is for a prince to lay foundations well, otherwise he will necessarily come to ruin. The chief foundations of all states, new as well as old or composite, are good laws and good armies; and since there cannot be good laws where there are no good armies, where they are good armies there must be good laws. I shall leave the laws out of the discussion and shall speak of the armies.

1 *Sixtus [IV]* Francesco della Rovere (1414–84), Pope from 1471 until his death.

2 *Duke Valentino* As Machiavelli mentions above, this is another name for Cesare Borgia.

3 *Pope Leo* Giovanni de' Medici (1475–1521), Pope Leo X from 1513 until his death. Highly political, he worked to extend the Medici family influence. He is now known for his papal bull against Martin Luther and his failure to check the Protestant Reformation.

I say, therefore, that the armed forces with which a prince defends his state are either his own, or they are mercenaries, auxiliaries, or mixed troops. Mercenaries and auxiliaries are useless and dangerous. If one holds his state using these forces, one will stand neither firm nor safe; for they are disunited, ambitious and without discipline, unfaithful, valiant before friends, cowardly before enemies; they have neither the fear of God nor fidelity to men. Ruin is deferred only so long as the attack is; for in peace one is robbed by them, and in war by the enemy. The fact is, they have no other attraction or reason to remain in the field than a trifling wage, which is not sufficient to make them willing to die for you. They are ready enough to be your soldiers while you do not wage war, but if war comes they desert or run from the foe. I have no trouble in proving this, for the ruin of Italy has been caused by nothing else than resting all her hopes for many years on mercenaries. Although they formerly made some display and appeared valiant amongst themselves, yet when the foreigners came they revealed what they were. Thus it was that Charles [VIII], King of France, was easily able to seize Italy with a piece of chalk;¹ and he who said that this was the result of our sins² told the truth—but the sins were not the ones they imagined, but were those I have related. And as they were the sins of princes, it is the princes who have also suffered the penalty.

I wish to explain further the problems with this sort of army. The mercenary captains are either capable men or they are not; if they are, you cannot trust them, because they always aspire to their own greatness, either by oppressing you, who are their master, or oppressing others contrary to your intentions; but if the captain is not skilful, you are ruined in the usual way.

If it is argued that whoever is armed will act in the same way, whether mercenary or not, I reply that when arms have to be resorted to, either by a prince or a republic, then the prince ought to go in person and perform the duty of captain; the republic has to send its citizens, and when one is sent who does not turn out satisfactorily, it must replace him, and when one is worthy, the republic must restrain him

so he does not exceed his authority. Experience has shown that only princes and armed republics make great progress, while mercenaries do nothing except damage; and it is more difficult for one of its citizens to take over a republic armed with an army of its own citizens than a republic with a foreign army. Rome and Sparta stood for many ages armed and free. The Swiss are very well armed and quite free.

The Carthaginians provide an example of an ancient use of mercenary armies. They were oppressed by their mercenary soldiers after the first war with the Romans,³ although the Carthaginians had their own citizens for captains. After the death of Epaminondas, the Thebans made Philip of Macedon⁴ captain of their army, and after victory he took away their liberty.

After the death of Duke Filippo,⁵ the Milanese hired Francesco Sforza against the Venetians. He, having overcome the enemy at Caravaggio, allied himself with them to crush his own employers, the Milanese. His father, Sforza, who was a soldier for Queen Johanna of Naples, left her unprotected, and as a result she was forced to throw herself into the arms of the King of Aragon, in order to save her kingdom. And if it is objected that the Venetians and Florentines formerly extended their dominions with mercenary armies, without their captains seizing their principalities, I reply that the Florentines in this case have been favored by chance. Among the able leaders, whom they had reason to fear, some failed to conquer, some met with opposition, and others have turned their ambitions elsewhere. One who did not conquer was Giovanni Acuto;⁶ since he did not conquer his fidelity cannot be proved; but every one will acknowledge that, had he conquered, the Florentines would have been at his mercy. Sforza always had the Bracceschi against him, so they checked each other. Francesco turned his ambition to Lombardy; Braccio⁷ against the Church and the kingdom of Naples.

1 *with a piece of chalk* The French had a practice of marking houses in which troops were to be quartered with chalk. Machiavelli is implying here that the French found little Italian resistance to their invasion.

2 *this was the result of our sins* Quote from Savonarola, who thought that the Italians' problems were punishment for their moral wickedness.

3 *the first war with the Romans* The First Punic War (264–241 BCE).

4 *Epaminondas ... Philip of Macedon* Epaminondas (c. 418–362 BCE) was a general and statesman who led Thebes to power and independence. Weakened by his wars, Thebes was taken over in 338 BCE by Philip II of Macedon (382–336 BCE).

5 *Duke Filippo* Filippo Visconti (1392–1447), duke of Milan.

6 *Giovanni Acuto* This is an Italianized version of the name of John Hawkwood, an English mercenary who fought in Italy beginning in 1360.

7 *Braccio* Andrea Braccio da Montone (1368–1424), important mercenary leader and later Lord of Perugia, Prince of Capua, and Governor of the Abruzzi.

But let us turn to recent events. The Florentines appointed as their captain Paolo Vitelli, a most prudent man, who had risen from the position of private citizen to the greatest renown. If this man had taken Pisa, nobody can deny that it would have been proper for the Florentines to cultivate his friendship, for if he became the soldier of their enemies they had no means of resisting, and if they had engaged him, they would have to obey him. The Venetians, if their achievements are considered, will be seen to have acted safely and gloriously so long as they sent their own men to war, and fought courageously using their armed gentry populace. This was before they began to fight on land. When they began to fight on land they abandoned this virtue and followed the usual practices of waging war in Italy. And in the beginning of the expansion of their territory on the mainland, they did not have much to fear from their captains, because they did not have much territory but had a great reputation. But when they expanded, as under Carmignola, they had a taste of this mistake. On the one hand, they had found him a courageous man (they beat the Duke of Milan under his leadership); but on the other, knowing how he had lost his taste for waging war, they feared they would no longer conquer under him. Yet they could not dismiss him for fear of losing that which they had acquired. In order to secure themselves against him, they were compelled to murder him. Their captains later were Bartolomeo da Bergamo, Roberto da San Severino, the Count of Pitigliano, and the like; under them they had to fear not gain of territory but loss, as happened afterwards at Vailà,¹ where in one battle they lost what they had acquired with so much difficulty over eight hundred years. Because with soldiers such as these, conquests come slowly, long delayed and inconsequential, but losses tend to be vast and can happen with astonishing speed.

With these examples I have reached Italy,² which has been ruled for many years by mercenaries. I wish to discuss

them more seriously, in order that, having seen their origin and progress, one may be better prepared to counteract them. You must understand that the empire has recently come to be repudiated in Italy, that the Pope has acquired more temporal power, and that Italy has been divided up into more states. Many of the great cities took up arms against their nobles, who, formerly favored by the emperor, kept them under control. The Church favored these cities so as to gain temporal power; in many others, citizens became princes. From this it came to pass that Italy fell partly into the hands of the Church and of several republics; and, since the priests making up the Church and the citizens making up the republics were both unaccustomed to bearing arms, both began to enlist foreigners.

The first who gave prestige to this sort of soldier was Alberigo da Conio,³ a native of the Romagna. Trained by him were, among others, Braccio and Sforza, who in their time were the arbiters of Italy. After these came all the other captains who till now have directed Italy's armies; and the end of all their valor has been, that she has been overrun by Charles [VIII], robbed by Louis [XII], ravaged by Ferdinand⁴ [II], and insulted by the Swiss. The principle that has guided them has been, first, to discredit the infantry so that they might increase their own prestige. They did this because, subsisting on their pay and without territory, they were unable to support many soldiers themselves, and a few infantry did not give them any authority; so they were led to employ cavalry. With a moderate cavalry force they were well-paid and honored; and it came to pass that in an army of twenty thousand soldiers, there were not to be found even two thousand foot soldiers. They had also used every art to lessen fatigue and danger to themselves and their soldiers, not killing in the fray, but taking prisoners and liberating without ransom. They did not attack towns at night, nor did the garrisons of the towns attack encampments at night; they did not surround a camp either with stockades or trenches, nor did they campaign in the winter. All these things were in line

¹ *Vailà* The Venetians were badly defeated in the battle here (also known as the Battle of Agnadello) by the French in 1509.

² *With these examples I have reached Italy* The events mentioned in this section relate to the period of the "Italian Wars," beginning in about 1450 and lasting past the time Machiavelli wrote this work (1513). Italy was divided among rival states, the strongest of which were Venice; Milan (ruled by Ludovico Sforza); Florence, which gained considerably under the rule of Lorenzo the Magnificent; the Papal States, expanding under the political popes of the late fifteenth century; and Naples, ruled by the Aragonese. Continuing battles among the Italians weakened them all, and opened the way, beginning around 1490, for meddling in Italian

affairs by the French (under Charles VIII, then Louis XII, then Francis I), the Germans (under Maximilian I, Emperor of the Holy Roman Empire), the Spanish (under Ferdinand of Aragon), and some cantons of Switzerland.

³ *Alberigo da Conio* Alberigo da Barbiano, count of Cunio (d. 1409); influential in replacing foreign mercenary troops with Italian mercenaries.

⁴ *Ferdinand* Ferdinand II (also known as Ferdinand of Aragon, 1452–1516), who unified Spain, gained control of several cities in Italy, and also gained control of large portions of the New World.

with their military code, and devised by them to avoid, as I have said, both fatigue and dangers; thus they have brought Italy to slavery and contempt.

Chapter 13: Concerning auxiliary, mixed, and citizen soldiers

Auxiliaries are forces that one calls in from a powerful neighbor for aid and defense, and these are as useless as mercenaries. Auxiliaries were used recently by Pope Julius in the Ferrara enterprise. Having seen the failure of his mercenaries, he arranged for armed assistance from Ferdinand, King of Spain. These forces may be useful and good in themselves, but for him who summons them they are always disadvantageous; for losing, one is undone, and winning, one is their captive.

Although ancient histories are full of examples, I want to emphasize the recent case of Pope Julius II, because one cannot fail to see the peril to which he was subjected. Wishing to win Ferrara, he threw himself entirely into the hands of a foreigner. But he had the good fortune that a third development prevented him from suffering the results of his rash choice. After his auxiliaries were routed at Ravenna, the Swiss rose up and drove out the conquerors (against everyone's expectation), and so he did not become prisoner of his enemies, who had fled, nor of his auxiliaries, since he had conquered with other troops than theirs.

The Florentines, being completely unarmed, sent ten thousand Frenchmen to take Pisa, a plan which endangered themselves more than at any of their previous predicaments.

The Emperor of Constantinople,¹ to oppose his neighbors, sent ten thousand Turks into Greece. When the war was finished, the Turks were not willing to leave; this was the beginning of the servitude of Greece to the infidels.

Only those who have no desire to conquer should make use of these armed forces, for they are much more hazardous than mercenaries. With them ruin is assured; they are all united, and they all owe obedience to others. Mercenaries who have conquered, on the other hand, need more time and better opportunities to injure you; they are not united, they are found and paid by you, and the person whom you have made their head is not immediately able to assume

enough authority to injure you. In conclusion, cowardice is the most dangerous quality in mercenaries; in auxiliaries, it is courage. The wise prince, therefore, has always avoided these soldiers and turned to his own and has been willing rather to lose using his own forces than to conquer using the forces of others, not deeming a victory real which is gained with foreign troops.

I shall never hesitate to cite Cesare Borgia and his actions. This Duke entered the Romagna with auxiliary troops, taking only French soldiers, and with them he captured Imola and Forli. But afterwards, because these forces did not appear reliable to him, he turned to mercenaries, judging them to be less dangerous, and enlisted the Orsini and Vitelli. But when he found them unreliable, unfaithful, and dangerous, he suppressed them and turned to his own men. The difference between these sorts of forces can easily be seen when one considers the difference there was in the reputation of the duke, on the one hand when he had French troops or when he had the Orsini and Vitelli, and on the other when he relied on his own soldiers, on whose fidelity he could always count. We find that his reputation grew and he was never esteemed more highly than when everyone saw that he was complete master of his own forces.

I did not intend to go beyond Italian and recent examples, but I am unwilling to omit Hiero, the Syracusan, he whom I have named above. This man, as I have said, having been made head of their army by the Syracusans, soon found out that a mercenary army, constituted like our Italian condottieri, was of no use. Since it appeared to him that he could neither keep them nor let them go, he had them all cut to pieces. Afterwards he made war with his own troops and not with soldiers belonging to others.

I wish also to call to mind an example from the Old Testament applicable to this subject. David² offered himself to Saul to fight Goliath, the Philistine champion. To give David courage, Saul offered him his own weapons; but David rejected them as soon as he had them on his back, saying he could make no use of them, and that he wished to meet the enemy with his own sling and his own knife. In conclusion, the arms of others either fail you, weigh you down, or tie you up.

1 *The Emperor of Constantinople* John VI Cantacuzenus (c. 1292–1383) was Byzantine emperor (1347–54). In his fight to become emperor, and to keep control later during civil war, he enlisted Turkish aid.

2 *David* Ancient king of Israel (c. 1000 BCE?) who extended its territory and influence by a series of military victories. His story is found in several books of the Old Testament, especially 1 Samuel and 2 Samuel.

Charles VII,¹ the father of King Louis XI,² having by good fortune and valor liberated France from the English, recognized the necessity of arming himself with his own soldiers, and he established ordinances in his kingdom to procure cavalry and infantry. Afterwards his son, King Louis, abolished the infantry and began to enlist the Swiss. This mistake, followed by others, is now seen to have endangered the kingdom. By raising the reputation of the Swiss, he diminished the value of his own troops. He destroyed the infantry altogether and subordinated his cavalry to others. Being so accustomed to fighting along with the Swiss, the French felt that they could not conquer without them. Hence it arises that the French could not stand against the Swiss, and without the Swiss they did not test their chances against others. The armies of the French have thus become mixed, partly mercenary and partly national. This combined force is much better than mercenaries alone or auxiliaries alone, yet much inferior to one's own forces. And this example proves it: the kingdom of France would be unconquerable if Charles VII's military institutions had been enlarged or maintained.

But men, showing poor judgment when establishing a policy that looks good at first, cannot see the poison that is hidden in it, as I have said above of consumptive fevers. Therefore, if he who rules a principality cannot recognize evils until they are upon him, he is not truly wise; and this insight is given to few. And examination of the first causes of the fall of the Roman Empire will show that it began when they enlisted the Goths. From that time the vigor of the Roman Empire began to decline, and all the valor which had raised it passed away to others.

I conclude, therefore, that no principality is secure without its own soldiers; on the contrary, it is entirely dependent on good fortune, not having the valor which in adversity would defend it. It has always been the opinion and judgment of wise men that nothing can be so uncertain or unstable as fame or power not founded on one's own strength.³ One's own forces are those which are composed either of subjects, citizens, or dependants; all others are

mercenaries or auxiliaries. And the way to organize one's own forces will be easily found if one reflects on the rules I have suggested, and if one considers how Philip [II], the father of Alexander the Great,⁴ and many republics and princes have armed and organized themselves. I have full confidence in their rules.

Chapter 14: That which concerns a prince on the subject of the art of war

A prince ought to have no other aim or thought than war and its organization and discipline. Nor should he study anything else; for this is the sole art that pertains to a ruler, with the power not only to maintain those who are born princes, but also often to enable private citizens to rise to that rank. It has been observed that when princes think more about luxury than of warfare they lose their states. The primary cause of losing power is the neglect of this art; and mastery of it enables the acquisition of a state.

Francesco Sforza, a private citizen, became Duke of Milan because he was armed; and his sons, because they avoided the hardships and troubles of arms, were both reduced from the rank of duke to that of private citizen. Among the many evils which being unarmed brings you is that it makes you contemptible; this is one of those disgraces against which a prince ought to guard himself, as I show later on. There is no comparison between the armed and the unarmed man. It would go against reason that an armed man should willingly obey one who is unarmed, or that an unarmed man should feel safe among armed servants. Because one is disdainful and the other suspicious, it is not possible for them to work well together. In like fashion a prince who does not understand the art of war, over and above the other misfortunes already mentioned, cannot be respected by his soldiers, and nor can he rely on them. He ought never, therefore, let the subject of war leave his thoughts; he ought to practice it not only in wartime but also in peacetime. This he can do in two ways, the one by action, the other by study.

As regards action, he ought above all things to keep his men well organized and drilled. He ought constantly to be hunting, by which he can accustom his body to hardships and learn something of the nature of localities, how the mountains rise, how the valleys open out, how the plains

1 Charles VII King of France (1403–61) from 1422 until his death.

2 King Louis XI King of France (1423–83) from 1461 until his death.

3 *nothing can be ... one's own strength* Machiavelli gives a Latin version: "*Quod nihil sit tam infirmum aut instabile quam fama potentiae non sua vi nixae*," somewhat misquoting the *Annals* of Tacitus 13, 19.

4 Alexander the Great King of Macedonia (356–323 BCE), Alexander conquered large portions of the Greek world.

lie, and understand the nature of rivers and marshes. In all this he should take the greatest care.

This knowledge is useful in two ways. First, he comes to know his country, and is better able to defend it. Second, by means of the knowledge and observation of his own local area, it will be easy for him to understand any other area which he must study later, because the hills, valleys, and plains, and rivers and marshes that are, for instance, in Tuscany, have a certain resemblance to those of other lands, so that with a knowledge of the different aspects of one area he can easily arrive at a knowledge of others. The prince who lacks this skill lacks an essential skill which a captain should possess, for it allows him to surprise his enemy, to select quarters, to lead armies, to organize the battle, and to besiege towns to his advantage.

Among other praises which writers have bestowed on Philopoemen,¹ Prince of the Achaeans, he has been commended because in time of peace he never had anything on his mind except methods of waging war. When he was in the country with friends, he often stopped and reasoned with them: "If the enemy should be upon that hill, and we should find ourselves here with our army, who would have the advantage? How should one best advance to meet the enemy, without breaking formation? If we should wish to retreat, how ought we to set about it? If they should retreat, how ought we to pursue?" And he would set forth to them, as he went, all the contingencies that might arise for an army; he would listen to their opinion and state his, accompanying it with reasons. These continual discussions meant that there could never arise unexpected circumstances for him to deal with in time of war.

As exercise for the intellect, the prince should read histories, and study there the actions of illustrious men, to see how they have borne themselves in war, and to examine the causes of their victories and defeats, so as to avoid the latter and imitate the former; and above all to do what some illustrious men have done: emulating their predecessors, and remembering their achievements and deeds. It is said that in this way Alexander the Great imitated Achilles, Caesar imitated Alexander, and Scipio² imitated Cyrus. Whoever

reads Xenophon's³ life of Cyrus will recognize that the glory of Scipio's life was imitation—that in chastity, affability, humanity, and generosity Scipio conformed to those things written of Cyrus by Xenophon.

A wise prince should follow such methods, and never be idle in peacetime, but rather work to increase his resources then so that they are available to him in adversity—so that if fortune changes it may find him prepared to resist her blows.

Chapter 15: Concerning things for which men, and especially princes, are praised or blamed

It remains now to see what ought to be the rules of conduct for a prince towards his subjects and his allies. As I know that many have written on this point, I expect I shall be considered presumptuous in mentioning the subject again, especially because, in discussing it, I shall depart from the methods of others. But because I intend my writing to be useful for the reader, it appears to me to be more appropriate to pursue real truth rather than imaginary matters. Many have pictured republics and principalities which in fact have never been known or seen, ignoring the great difference between how one ought to live and how one lives in fact. Neglecting to consider what *is* done because one is concentrating on what *ought to be* done is more likely to lead to ruin than to preservation. A man who wishes to act entirely on the basis of his declarations about morality will soon meet with destruction among those with no such scruples.

Therefore it is necessary that a prince who wishes to hold his own know how to do wrong, and to make use of such knowledge when necessary. Putting aside imaginary matters concerning a prince, and discussing only those that are real, I say that all men when they are spoken of are judged in terms of those qualities which bring them either blame or praise. Such is especially true of princes, because of their high status. Thus it is that one is reputed generous, another miserly (I use a Tuscan term *miserio*, because *avarro* in our language means someone who wants to possess by robbery, while *miserio* means someone who avoids using what he has). One is reputed generous, one rapacious; one

1 *Philopoemen* General of the Achaean league (252–182 BCE), leader of a failed attempt to resist Roman domination of Greece.

2 *Achilles* Hero of Homer's *Iliad*; *Caesar* Julius Caesar (102–44 BCE), Roman general, statesman, and historian, who led Roman forces in establishing control over large areas of Europe, was established by the people as dictator for life and then assassinated by

republican political enemies; *Scipio* Scipio Africanus (236–183 BCE), renowned Roman general who defeated Hannibal.

3 *Xenophon* Soldier and historian (c. 431–355 BCE); the reference here is to his *Anabasis*.

cruel, one compassionate; one faithless, another faithful; one effeminate and cowardly, another bold and brave; one affable, another haughty; one lascivious, another chaste; one sincere, another cunning; one hard, another easy; one grave, another frivolous; one religious, another unbelieving, and the like. And I know that everyone will agree that it would be most praiseworthy in a prince to exhibit all the qualities above that are considered good. But because such qualities can neither be entirely possessed nor completely observed—human conditions do not permit it—it is necessary for him to be prudent enough to know how to avoid scandal because of vices which would result in his losing his state. He should also avoid, if possible, those vices which would not result in this loss. But if this is not possible, he need not overly concern himself with those less serious vices. Moreover, he need not worry about being reproached for those vices without which it would be difficult to save the state; for if everything is considered carefully, it will be found that something which looks like virtue, if followed, would result in ruin; while something else, which looks like vice, when pursued brings him security and prosperity.

Chapter 16: Concerning generosity and miserliness

Let me begin with the first of the above-mentioned qualities; I say that it would be well to be reputed generous. Nevertheless, generosity exercised in a way that does not bring you the reputation for it, injures you; if one exercises it honestly as it should be exercised, it may not become known, and you will not avoid criticism for its opposite. Therefore, anyone wishing to maintain a reputation for generosity must omit nothing in the way of magnificent display; a prince thus inclined will use up all his property in such acts, and will be compelled in the end, if he wishes to maintain a reputation for generosity, to unduly burden his people, and tax them, and do everything he can to get money. This will soon make him hateful to his subjects, he will become poor, and he will be little valued by anyone. Thus having offended many and rewarded few with his generosity, he will feel the effects of the people's unrest and become imperilled at the first sign of danger. Recognizing this himself, and wishing to draw back from it, he will run into criticism for being miserly.

Since a prince is unable to exercise the virtue of generosity in such a way that it is recognized without damaging

his position, he should not be afraid of being considered miserly. That is the wise course to take. For in time he will come to be considered more generous: with good economic management, his revenues will be sufficient; he can defend himself against all attacks, and he will be able to engage in enterprises without burdening his people. Thus he will be able to be generous to the many people from whom he does not take, and miserly towards the few to whom he does not give.

We have not seen great things done in our time except by those who have been considered miserly; the rest have failed. Pope Julius the Second was assisted in reaching the papacy by a reputation for generosity, yet he did not strive afterwards to keep it up. When he made war on the King of France, and when he engaged in many other wars, he did so without imposing any extraordinary tax on his subjects, for he funded his additional expenses out of his long thriftiness. The present King of Spain would not have undertaken or successfully carried out so many enterprises if he were extravagant enough to have a reputation for generosity. Therefore, in order that a prince does not have to rob his subjects, that he can defend himself, that he does not become poor and abject, and that he is not forced to become greedy and grasping, a prince ought to consider the reputation for miserliness unimportant. It is one of those vices which will enable him to govern.

If anyone should say: "Caesar obtained empire by generosity, and many others have reached the highest positions by having been generous, and by being considered so," I answer: "Either you are a prince in fact, or you are on the way to becoming one. In the first case this generosity is dangerous, in the second it is indeed necessary to be considered generous. Caesar was one of those who wished to become pre-eminent in Rome; but if he had not moderated his expenses after taking power, he would have destroyed his government." And if anyone should reply: "Many have been princes, and have done great things with armies, who have been considered very generous," I reply: Either a prince spends his own money, or his subjects', or someone else's. In the first case he ought to be sparing, in the second he ought not to neglect any opportunity for generosity. And to the prince who goes forth with his army, supporting it by pillage, sack, and extortion, dealing with others' belongings, this generosity is necessary, otherwise he would not be followed by his soldiers. And of that which is neither yours nor your subjects' you can be a generous donor, as were Cyrus, Caesar, and Alexander; because it does not take away your

reputation if you squander that of others, but adds to it; it is only squandering your own that injures you.

There is nothing that destroys so rapidly as generosity, for as you exercise it you lose the power to do so, and so become either poor or despised, or else, in avoiding poverty, grasping and hated. A prince should guard, above all things, against being despised and hated; and generosity leads you to both. Therefore it is wiser to have a reputation for miserliness, which brings criticism without hatred, than to be compelled, through seeking a reputation for generosity, to incur a name for rapacity and thereby become detested.

Chapter 17: Concerning cruelty and mercy, and whether it is better to be loved than feared

Coming now to the other qualities mentioned above, I say that every prince ought to desire to be considered merciful and not cruel. Nevertheless, he ought to take care not to misuse this mercy. Cesare Borgia was considered cruel, but his cruelty brought order to the Romagna, unified it, and restored it to peace and loyalty. And if this is considered correctly, he will be seen to have been much more merciful than the Florentine people, who, to avoid a reputation for cruelty, permitted Pistoia¹ to be destroyed. So long as a prince keeps his subjects united and loyal, he ought not to mind the criticism of cruelty. If he displays cruelty in a few cases, he will be more merciful than those who, through too much mercy, allow disorder to arise, and murders or robberies follow; these are liable to injure everyone, while executions ordered by a prince offend the individual only.

A new prince, above all, will find it impossible to avoid a reputation for cruelty, because new states are full of dangers. Hence Virgil, through the mouth of Dido, excuses the inhumanity of her reign because it is new, saying “*Res dura, et regni novitas me talia cogunt Moliri, et late fines custode tueri*.”²

Nevertheless the prince ought to be slow to believe and to act. Nor should he himself show fear; instead he should proceed in a temperate manner with prudence and humanity, so that too much confidence may not make him incautious and too much distrust render him intolerable.

A question arises here: is it better to be loved than feared, or better to be feared than loved? It may be answered that one should wish to be both. But, because it is difficult to unite them in one person, it is much safer to be feared than to be loved, when one of the two must be dispensed with. This is to be asserted in general of men: they are ungrateful, fickle, false, cowardly, and covetous. As long as you succeed they are yours entirely; they will offer you their blood, property, life and children, as is said above, when the need is far distant; but when it approaches they turn against you. And that prince who, relying entirely on their promises, has neglected other precautions, is ruined; friendships that are obtained by payments, and not by greatness or nobility of mind, may indeed be earned, but they are not secured, and in time of need cannot be relied upon. Men are less hesitant to offend someone who is beloved than someone who is feared, for love is preserved by a link of obligation which, owing to the baseness of men, is broken at every opportunity for their advantage. Fear, on the other hand, preserves you with a dread of punishment which never fails.

A prince ought to inspire fear in such a way that, if he does not win love, he nevertheless avoids hatred, because he can endure being feared easily while he is not hated. This will occur as long as he leaves alone the property of his subjects, and their women. When it is necessary for him to proceed against the life of someone, he must do it with proper justification and manifest cause. But above all things he must keep his hands off the property of others, because men more quickly forget the death of their father than the loss of their patrimony. Besides, pretexts for taking away property are never lacking; he who has once begun to live by robbery will always find pretexts for seizing what belongs to others. Reasons for taking lives, on the other hand, are more difficult to find and sooner lapse. But when a prince is with his army, and has a multitude of soldiers under control, then it is quite necessary he not worry about the reputation of cruelty, for without it he would never keep his army united or attentive to its duties.

Among the wonderful deeds of Hannibal³ is this one. He led an enormous army, composed of many various races of men, to fight in foreign lands, and no dissensions arose either among them or against the prince, either in times of good fortune or bad. This success resulted from nothing else than his inhuman cruelty, which, with his boundless courage, made him revered and terrible in the sight of his

¹ *Pistoia* A city under Florentine rule. Florence forcibly ended a factional conflict there in 1501–02.

² *Res dura ... custode tueri* “Harsh necessity, and the newness of my kingdom, force me to do such things and to guard my frontiers everywhere” (Virgil, *Aeneid* 1, 563–64).

³ *Hannibal* Commander of the Carthaginian army (247–183 BCE) during the Second Punic War against Rome.

soldiers: without that cruelty, his other virtues would not have been sufficient to produce this effect. Short-sighted writers admire his deeds from one perspective and from another condemn the principal cause of them.

That other virtues would not have been sufficient in such a case may be shown too by the case of Scipio, a most excellent man, not just of his own time, but of all times. Nevertheless, his army rebelled against him in Spain; the cause was he was too tolerant, and gave his soldiers more license than is consistent with military discipline. For this he was upbraided in the Senate by Fabius Maximus,¹ and called the corrupter of the Roman soldiery. The Locrians were destroyed by one of Scipio's officers, but he did not avenge this or punish the insolence of the officer. This was the result of his easy nature, so much so that it was said in the Senate by someone wishing to excuse him, that there were many men who knew how not to err better than they knew how to correct the errors of others. Scipio's nature would eventually have destroyed his fame and glory, if he had manifested it during the empire; but since he was under the control of the Senate, this injurious characteristic not only concealed itself, but contributed to his glory.

Returning to the question of being feared or loved, I conclude with this: men love according to their own free will, but fear according to the will of the prince. Therefore a wise prince should base his rule on that which is in his own control and not in the control of others. He must endeavor only to avoid hatred, as I said.

Chapter 18: Concerning the way in which princes should keep their word

Everyone knows how praiseworthy it is for a prince to act in good faith—to be honest and keep his word, and to live with integrity and not with deceit. Nevertheless our experience has been that those princes who have done great things have held good faith of little account, and have known how to cunningly manipulate men's minds. In the end they have overcome those who have relied on their word.

You must know there are two ways of fighting—one by the law, the other by force. The first method is appropriate for men, the second for beasts. But because the first is frequently not sufficient, it is often necessary to have recourse to the second. Therefore, it is necessary for a prince

to understand how to avail himself of the beast and the man. This has been figuratively taught to princes by ancient writers, who describe how Achilles and many other princes of old were given to the Centaur² Chiron to nurse. The centaur brought them up in his discipline; just as they had for a teacher one who was half beast and half man, so it is necessary for a prince to know how to make use of both natures. A prince who has one without the other does not last.

A prince who has to act knowingly as a beast, ought to choose the fox and the lion. The lion cannot defend himself against snares, and the fox cannot defend himself against wolves. Therefore, it is necessary to be a fox to discover the snares and a lion to terrify the wolves. Those who rely simply on the lion lack understanding.

Therefore a wise lord cannot, nor ought he to, keep faith when doing so may be turned against him, and when the reasons that caused him to pledge his good faith exist no longer. If men were entirely good this precept would not hold, but because they are bad, and will not keep faith with you, you too are not bound to observe it with them. There will always be legitimate reasons for a prince to fail to keep his word. Endless modern examples could be given, showing how many treaties and engagements have been made void and of no effect through the faithlessness of princes; he who has known best how to employ the fox has succeeded best.

But it is necessary to know how to disguise this characteristic well, and to be a great pretender and dissembler. Men are so simple-minded, and so subject to present necessities, that he who seeks to deceive will always find someone who will allow himself to be deceived. One recent example I cannot pass over in silence. Alexander VI did nothing else but deceive men, and never thought of doing otherwise, and always found victims; there never was a man who had greater power in asserting, or who with greater oaths would affirm a thing, yet would observe it less. Nevertheless his deceits always succeeded according to his wishes, because he well understood this side of humanity.

Therefore, it is not necessary for a prince to have all the good qualities I have enumerated, but it is necessary for him to appear to have them. I shall dare to say this also, that to have them and always to observe them is injurious, while to *appear* to have them is useful. The prince may appear merciful, faithful, humane, religious, upright, and even be so, but he must always keep a mind so disposed that should

¹ *Fabius Maximus* Roman politician and soldier (c. 275–203 BCE); consul five times, and twice dictator.

² *Centaur* In Greek mythology, a half horse, half man.

it become necessary for him not to be so, he will know how to change to the opposite.

You have to understand this: a prince, especially a new one, cannot behave in all those ways for which men are esteemed; in order to maintain the state, he is often forced to act contrary to faith, friendship, humanity, and religion. Therefore it is necessary for him to have a mind ready to turn itself accordingly as the winds and variations of fortune force it. Yet, as I have said above, he should not diverge from the good if he can avoid doing so. It is only if he is compelled to diverge from the good that he must know how to go about it.

For this reason a prince ought to take care that he never let anything slip from his lips that is not full of the above-named five qualities, so that he may appear to anyone who sees and hears him altogether merciful, faithful, humane, upright, and religious. There is nothing more necessary to appear to have than this last quality, since men judge generally more by eye than by hand—anyone can see you, but few can be so close to you that they can touch you. Every one sees what you appear to be, few really know what you are, and those few dare not oppose themselves to the opinion of the many, who have the majesty of the state to defend them. In the actions of all men, and especially of princes, which it is not prudent to challenge, one judges by the result.

For that reason, let a prince have the credit of conquering and holding his state; then his means will always be considered honest, and he will be praised generally, because the vulgar are always taken by what a thing seems to be and by its results; and in the world there are only the vulgar, for the few have no place when the many hold sway.

One prince¹ of the present time, whom it is not well to name, never preaches anything else but peace and good faith, and to both he is most hostile. Either of them, had he kept it, would have deprived him of reputation and kingdom many a time.

Chapter 19: That one should avoid being despised and hated

I have now spoken of the more important characteristics mentioned above, and will discuss the others briefly. The general idea here is that the prince must consider, as I said before, how to avoid what will make him hated or treated

with contempt; if he succeeds at this, he will have done his part, and need not fear danger from other vices.

Above all, people would hate him for being greedy and grasping, as I have said—for usurping his subjects' property and women; he must abstain from both. When neither their property nor honor is touched, the majority of men live content, and he has only to contend with the ambition of a few, whom he can easily control in many ways.

What makes him despised is being considered changeable, frivolous, effeminate, mean-spirited, irresolute, from all of which a prince should guard himself as carefully as a sailor avoids reefs. He should try to show greatness, courage, gravity, and fortitude in his actions; and in his private dealings with his subjects let him show that his judgments are irrevocable, and maintain a reputation for himself that would prevent anyone from hoping either to deceive him or to get round him.

That prince is highly esteemed who conveys this impression of himself, and he who is highly esteemed is not easily conspired against; provided it is well known that he is an excellent man and revered by his people, he can be attacked only with difficulty. For this reason a prince ought to have two fears: one internal, regarding his subjects, and the other external, regarding foreign powers. From the latter he is defended by being well armed and having good allies, and if he is well armed he will have good friends. And internal affairs will always remain quiet when things are quiet externally, unless they were already disturbed by conspiracy. And even if there is external trouble, if he has carried out his preparations and has lived as I have said, as long as he does not despair, he will resist every attack, just as I said Nabis the Spartan did.

But concerning his subjects, when external affairs are disturbed, he has to fear only that they will conspire secretly; and a prince can easily guard himself from this by avoiding being hated and despised, and by keeping the people satisfied with him—this, as I said above at length, must be accomplished. And one of the most efficacious remedies that a prince can have against conspiracies is not to be hated and despised by the people, for conspirators against a prince always expect to please the people by his removal. But when the conspirator can look forward only to offending the people he will not have the courage to take such a course, for the difficulties that confront a conspirator are infinite. As experience shows, there have been many conspiracies, but few successful ones. The reason for this is that if you want to embark on a conspiracy, you cannot

1 One prince Often taken to be Ferdinand of Spain.

act alone; you must have co-conspirators, and you naturally look for them among those you believe to be malcontents. But as soon as you have disclosed your intentions to a malcontent you have given him the means for contenting himself, for he can seek his own advantage by denouncing you. Gain in this way is assured, while participation in the conspiracy is risky and dangerous. So a co-conspirator who keeps faith with you must be a very rare friend of yours, or a thoroughly obstinate enemy of the prince.

Putting matters briefly: on the side of the conspirator, there is nothing but fear, jealousy, and prospect of punishment to terrify him; but on the side of the prince there is the majesty of the principality, the laws, the protection of friends and of the state to defend him; so that, adding to all these things the popular goodwill, it is impossible that anyone should be so rash as to conspire. For whereas in general the conspirator has much to fear before carrying out his plot, in this case he has more to fear afterwards; his plot will make the people his enemy and thus he will have no hope for escape.

Endless examples could be given on this subject, but I will content myself with one, which occurred within the memory of our fathers. Annibale Bentivoglio, who was prince in Bologna (grandfather of the present Annibale), was murdered by the Canneschi, who had conspired against him. Not one of his family survived but Giovanni,¹ who was then a child. Immediately after the assassination the people rose and murdered all the Canneschi. This sprung from the popular goodwill which the house of Bentivoglio enjoyed in those days in Bologna. Nobody remained there after the death of Annibale who was capable of ruling the state; but the good will of the family was so great that when the Bolognese, who were aware that one of the family, believed to be the son of a blacksmith, lived in Florence, they sent to Florence for him, and installed him as the ruler of the city. He ruled until Giovanni came of age.

For this reason I consider that a prince ought to reckon conspiracies of little account when his people hold him in esteem; but when the people are vehemently hostile and bear hatred towards him, he should fear everything and everybody. Well-ordered states and wise princes have taken every care not to drive the nobles to desperation, and to keep the people satisfied and contented; this is one of the most important concerns a prince can have.

¹ *Giovanni* Giovanni Bentivogli (1438–1508), ruler of Bologna from 1462 to 1506.

Among the best ordered and governed kingdoms of our times is France; in it are found many good institutions on which the liberty and security of the king depend. The foremost of these institutions is the parliament. Its authority is of great importance; the founder of the kingdom, knowing the ambition of the nobility and their boldness, thought that a bit in their mouths would be necessary to hold them back. On the other side, knowing the people's hatred of the nobles, founded in fear, he wished to protect them. Yet he was not anxious for this to be the particular concern of the king. Therefore, to protect himself against blame from the nobles for favoring the people, and from the people for favoring the nobles, he set up an arbiter,² who could beat down the great and favor the lesser without burdening the king. It is not possible to have a better or a more prudent arrangement, or a greater source of security for the king and kingdom. One can draw another important conclusion from this: princes ought to leave distasteful tasks to others, and keep the pleasant ones for themselves. And further, I consider that a prince ought to cherish the nobles, but not so as to make himself hated by the people.

It may appear, perhaps, to some who have examined the lives and deaths of the Roman emperors that many of them provide examples contrary to my opinion, in that some of them have lived nobly and showed great qualities of soul, but nevertheless have lost their empire or have been killed by subjects who have conspired against them. Wishing, therefore, to answer these objections, I will recall the characters of some of the emperors, and will show that the causes of their ruin were not different from those I have already mentioned; and I will bring forward noteworthy matters for those who study those times.

It seems to me sufficient to take all those emperors who succeeded to the throne from Marcus the philosopher down to Maximinus; they were Marcus and his son Commodus, Pertinax, Julian, Severus and his son Antoninus Caracalla, Macrinus, Heliogabalus, Alexander, and Maximinus.³

² *arbiter* That is, the Parliament.

³ *Marcus the philosopher* Marcus Aurelius, emperor from 161 to 180; *Commodus* Son of Marcus Aurelius, ruled from 180 to 193; *Pertinax* Ruled next for a short time; *Julian* Didius Julianus, ruled next for a short time; *Severus and his son Antoninus Caracalla* Septimius Severus ruled from 193 to 211, his son Antonius (nicknamed Caracalla) from 211 to 217; *Macrinus* Ruled next for a little over a year; *Heliogabalus* Also known as Elagabalus, ruled from 218 to 222; *Alexander* Severus Alexander ruled from 222 to 235; *Maximinus* Maximinus Thrax ruled until 238.

We should note first that in other principalities only the ambition of the nobles and the insolence of the people have to be contended with, but the Roman emperors had a third difficulty: having to deal with the cruelty and greed of their soldiers, a matter so beset with difficulties that it was the ruin of many. It was difficult to satisfy both the soldiers and the people, because the people loved peace, and for this reason they loved the unambitious prince, while the soldiers loved the warlike prince who was bold, cruel, and rapacious, and were quite willing to see him exercise these characteristics against the people, so that they could get double pay and give vent to their greed and cruelty. So it happened that those emperors who, either by nature and family or by experience, possessed no great reputation, were always overthrown. Most of them, especially those who had come to power recently as new princes, recognizing the difficulty of these two opposing factions, were inclined to appease the soldiers, caring little about injuring the people. This course was necessary, because, as princes cannot help being hated by someone, they ought, first, to avoid being hated by everyone, and when they cannot manage this, they ought to try hard to avoid the hatred of the most powerful. As a result, those emperors who through inexperience needed special support allied themselves more readily with the soldiers than with the people. Whether this course turned out to be advantageous for them or not depended upon whether the prince knew how to maintain authority over the soldiers.

For these reasons Marcus [Aurelius], Pertinax, and Alexander—all men who lived modest lives, all lovers of justice, enemies of cruelty, humane, and benign—all except Marcus came to a sad end. Marcus alone lived and died honored, because he had succeeded to the throne by right of birth, and owed nothing either to the soldiers or the people. Afterwards, being respected because of his many virtues, he always kept both groups in their places, and was neither hated nor despised.

But Pertinax was made emperor against the wishes of the soldiers. They had become accustomed to a life free from moral restraint under Commodus, and could not endure the honest life to which Pertinax wished to restrict them. Hating him for this reason, and additionally feeling contempt for his old age, they overthrew him at the very beginning of his administration.

Here it should be noted that hatred is acquired as much by good works as by bad ones. Therefore, as I said before, a prince wishing to keep his state is very often forced to do evil; for when the group you need to support

you is corrupt—it may be either the people or the soldiers or the nobles—you have to gratify their corrupt inclinations; to act according to the principles of good works would harm you.

But consider Alexander, a man acknowledged to be of great good. Among the good deeds credited to him is this: that in the fourteen years he held the empire, he put no one to death without trial. Nevertheless, being considered effeminate and a man who allowed himself to be governed by his mother, he was despised, the army conspired against him, and murdered him.

Consider now the characters of the opposite sort of Commodus, Severus, Antoninus Caracalla, and Maximinus. You will find them all cruel and rapacious—men who, to satisfy their soldiers, did not hesitate to commit every kind of iniquity against the people. All except Severus came to a bad end; Severus had so much ability that he reigned successfully, keeping the soldiers loyal, although he oppressed the people. His valor made him so much admired that the people were astonished and awed and the soldiers respectful and satisfied. And because the actions of this man, as a new prince, were great, I wish to show briefly how well he knew how to play the parts of the fox and the lion—the natures, as I said above, that a prince must imitate.

Learning of the indecisiveness of the Emperor Julian, he persuaded the army in Slavonia, of which he was captain, that it would be right to go to Rome and avenge the death of Pertinax, who had been killed by the praetorian soldiers. Under this pretext, without appearing to aspire to the throne, he moved his army to Rome, and reached Italy before it was known that he had departed. On his arrival at Rome, the Senate, through fear, elected him emperor and killed Julian. After this Severus, who wished to make himself master of the whole empire, faced two problems—one in Asia, where Niger, head of the Asiatic army, had himself proclaimed emperor; the other in the west where Albinus also aspired to the throne. Since he considered it dangerous to declare himself hostile to both, he decided to attack Niger and to deceive Albinus. To the latter he wrote that, having been elected emperor by the Senate, he was willing to share that dignity with him and send him the title of Caesar. Moreover, he said that the Senate had made Albinus his coequal. Albinus accepted these claims as true. But after Severus had conquered and killed Niger, and settled matters in the east, he returned to Rome and complained to the Senate that Albinus did not recognize the benefits that he had received, and had treacherously sought to murder

him; so, Severus claimed, he must punish Albinus for this ingratitude. Afterwards he sought him out in France, and took both his government and his life. Anyone who carefully examines the actions of Severus will find him a most savage lion and a most cunning fox; he will be found feared and respected by everyone, and not hated by the army; so nobody should be surprised that he, the new emperor, could hold on to his empire so well, because his great reputation always protected him from that hatred which the people might have conceived against him for his violence.

His son Antoninus was a most eminent man, and had very excellent qualities, which made him admirable in the sight of the people and acceptable to the soldiers. He was a warlike man, inured to fatigue, despising delicate food and other luxuries; this made him loved by the armies. Nevertheless, his ferocity and cruelty were so great, unprecedented even (after countless individual murders, he slaughtered a large number of the people of Rome and all those of Alexandria), that he became hated by the whole world. He also was feared by those he had around him, to such an extent that a centurion murdered him in the midst of his army.

I emphasize that deaths like this, deliberately inflicted by a determined and desperate individual, cannot be avoided by princes, because anyone who does not fear to die can inflict them. But a prince need not fear them greatly because they are very rare; he has only to be careful not to commit any grave injury against those whom he employs or has around him in the service of the state. Antoninus had not taken this care, but had scornfully killed a brother of that centurion, whom he also threatened daily, yet retained among his bodyguards. This, it turned out, was a rash thing to do, and proved the emperor's ruin.

But we now come to Commodus. It should have been very easy for him to hold on to the rule of the empire, for, being the son of Marcus, he had inherited it, and he had only to follow in the footsteps of his father to please his people and soldiers. But, being by nature cruel and brutal, he turned to pleasing the soldiers and corrupting them, so that he might indulge his greediness at the people's cost. On the other hand, he failed to maintain his dignity, often descending into the arena to compete with gladiators, and doing other vile things unworthy of the imperial majesty. Thus, the soldiers viewed him with contempt, and being hated by one party and despised by the other, he was conspired against and killed.

A discussion of the character of Maximinus remains. He was a very warlike man, and the armies, being disgusted

with the softness of Alexander, of whom I have already spoken, killed him and elected Maximinus to the throne. He did not hold it for long, for two things made him hated and despised: first, he was of low birth and had tended sheep on Thrace—this was well known to all, bringing him the contempt of everyone and causing him to lose considerable dignity in everyone's eyes; second, at the beginning of his rule he delayed going to Rome to take possession of the emperor's throne. Further, he had gained a reputation for the utmost ferocity because of his responsibility for many cruelties practiced by his prefects in Rome and elsewhere in the empire, so that the whole world was moved by contempt at his ignoble nature and by hatred caused by fear of his cruelty. First Africa rebelled, then the Senate with all the people of Rome, and all Italy plotted against him—including even his army, which, besieging Aquileia and having difficulty taking it, were disgusted with his cruelties, and fearing him less when they found so many against him, murdered him.

I do not wish to discuss Heliogabalus, Macrinus, or Julian, who, being thoroughly contemptible, were quickly destroyed; but I will conclude this discourse by saying that princes in our times have less difficulty giving extraordinary satisfaction to their soldiers. Although these princes have to give soldiers some indulgence, that is easily done. The reason is that none of these princes have armies that have evolved along with the government and administration of the provinces, as was the case with the armies of the Roman Empire. It was then necessary to give more satisfaction to the soldiers than to the people, but it is now necessary that all princes, except the Turk and the Sultan,¹ satisfy the people more than the soldiers, because the people are more powerful.

From the above I have excepted the Turk. He always keeps around him twelve thousand infantry and fifteen thousand cavalry. The security and strength of the kingdom depend on these forces, and it is necessary that he should keep them loyal, putting aside consideration for the people. The kingdom of the Sultan is similar; it is entirely in the hands of soldiers,² and he must also keep them as his friends, without regard to the people. But you must note that the state of the Sultan is unlike all other principalities, in that it is like the Christian pontificate, which cannot be

1 *the Turk and the Sultan* The ruler of Turkey (that is, of the Ottoman Empire) from 1512 to 1520 was Selim I. "The Sultan" refers to the ruler of Egypt.

2 *in the hands of soldiers* From 1250 to 1517, Egypt was controlled by the Mamelukes, a powerful military caste.

called either a hereditary or a newly formed principality; in both, the sons of the old prince do not rule by inheritance. The new ruler is elected to that position by those who have that authority. And since this is an ancient custom, it cannot be called a new principality, because there are none of those difficulties in it that are met with in new ones. Although the prince is new, the constitution of the state is old, and it is designed so as to receive him as if he were its hereditary lord.

But returning to our topic, I say that everyone who considers it will agree that both hatred and contempt have been fatal to the above-named emperors, and will also recognize how it came to pass that in each of these groups, only some came to a happy end, although some acted in one way, while others acted in a different manner. It would have been useless and dangerous for Pertinax and Alexander, being new princes, to imitate Marcus, who was heir to the principality; likewise, it would have been utterly destructive to Caracalla, Commodus, and Maximinus to have imitated Severus, since they did not have sufficient ability to follow in his footsteps. Therefore a prince, new to the principality, cannot imitate the actions of Marcus; nor, again, should he follow those of Severus. But he ought to take from Severus those methods which are necessary to found his state, and from Marcus those which are proper and glorious to keep a state that may already be stable and firm.

Chapter 20: Are fortresses, and many other things to which princes often resort, advantageous or hurtful?

Some princes have disarmed their subjects in order to hold the state securely; some have kept the towns under their rule divided; some have encouraged hostility against themselves; some have tried to gain the support of those whom they distrusted in the beginning of their governments; some have built fortresses; and some have overthrown and destroyed them. Although one cannot give a final judgment on these things unless one possesses the particulars of those circumstances in which such a decision has to be made, nevertheless I will speak as comprehensively as possible.

No new prince has ever disarmed his subjects. Rather, when he has found them unarmed he has always armed them; when you arm your subjects, those arms become yours. Those men who were distrusted become faithful, and those who were faithful are kept so, and your subjects

become your staunch supporters. You cannot arm all your subjects, but when those whom you do arm have benefited, the others can be handled more freely. This difference in their treatment, which they quite understand, makes the former your dependents, while the latter excuse you, recognizing that those more willing to put themselves in danger and those who perform greater service must necessarily receive the greatest reward. But when you disarm them, you at once offend them by showing that you distrust them, expecting either cowardice or disloyalty from them; either of these breeds hatred against you. Then, because you cannot remain unarmed, it follows that you will need to hire mercenaries, who have the characteristics noted above. Even if they are good, they will not be sufficiently strong to protect you against powerful enemies and distrusted subjects. Therefore, as I have said, a new prince in a new principality should always arm his subjects there; histories are full of examples.

When a prince acquires a new state which he adds as a province to existing principalities, on the other hand, it is necessary to disarm the men of that state, except for those who have supported the prince in acquiring it. Even those supporters, over time and as opportunities arise, should be made weak and effeminate; and matters should be managed in such a way that all the armed men in the state are your own soldiers, who were stationed near you in your old state.

Our forefathers—those who were thought wise—used to say that it was necessary to hold Pistoia by factions and Pisa by fortresses. With this principle in mind, they fostered quarrels in some of their subject towns so as to keep possession of them more easily. This may have worked well enough in those times when there was a balance of power in Italy, but I do not believe that it can be accepted as a precept for today, because I do not believe that competing factions can ever be of use. Rather, it is certain that when the enemy comes upon you in a divided city you will quickly be defeated, because the weaker party will always assist the outside forces and the other will not be able to resist.

The Venetians—motivated, I think, by the above reasons—fostered the growth of the Guelph and Ghibelline factions in their subject cities. They never allowed the factions to shed each other's blood, but they encouraged disputes amongst them, so that the citizens, distracted by their differences, would not unite against them. But this, as we saw, did not turn out as expected; after the rout at Vailà, one party at once took courage and seized the entire state. A prince who uses such methods reveals his own weakness;

such factions will never be permitted in a vigorous principality. These methods for enabling one more easily to manage one's subjects are only useful in times of peace. If war comes, these policies are proved to be mistaken.

Without doubt, princes become great when they overcome the difficulties and obstacles confronting them. Therefore Fortune, when she desires to enlarge the reputation of a new prince (who has a greater need to earn renown than does a hereditary prince) causes enemies to arise and take action against him; that gives the new prince the opportunity of overcoming them, and mounting higher, as by a ladder which his enemies have raised. For this reason many consider that a wise prince, when he has the opportunity, ought cleverly to foster some animosity against himself, so that, having crushed it, his renown may rise higher.

Princes, especially new ones, have received more loyalty and assistance from men who at the beginning of their rule were distrusted than from those who at the beginning were trusted. Pandolfo Petrucci, Prince of Siena, ruled his state by relying more on those who had been distrusted than on others. But on this question one cannot speak generally, for it varies so much with individual cases. I will only say this: men who at the beginning of a principedom's rule have been hostile, can always be won over with the greatest ease at the moment when they need assistance or support. They will then stay strongly loyal to the prince, because they know it is necessary to counteract through their actions the bad impression which the prince had formed of them initially. So the prince always extracts more profit from those who were at first hostile to him than he does those who, serving him with too much security, may neglect his affairs.

And since the subject demands it, I must not fail to warn a prince who has acquired a new state by means of support given to him secretly by some in the new state, that he must consider well the reasons which motivated those who favor him. If the motive is not a natural affection towards him, but only discontent with the previous government, then he will only keep them friendly with great trouble and difficulty; it will be impossible to satisfy them. Examples from ancient and modern times show the reasons for this: it is easier for the prince to make friends out of those men who were contented under the former government, and are therefore his enemies, than out of those who, being discontented with it, were favorable to him and encouraged him to seize it.

In order to hold their states more securely, princes have customarily built fortresses to serve as a bridle and bit to

plotters against them, and as a place of refuge from a first attack. I praise this system because it has been used for a long time. Nevertheless, in our time we have seen Nicolo Vitelli demolish two fortresses in Citta di Castello in order to keep possession of that state; Guidubaldo, Duke of Urbino, when returning to his rule from which he had been driven by Cesare Borgia, tore down all the fortresses in that province to their foundations, thinking that this would make his rule more secure; the Bentivoglio returning to Bologna came to a similar decision. Fortresses, therefore, may be useful or not, according to circumstances; though they may do you good in one way, they may injure you in another. We may thus sum it up in this way: a prince who has more to fear from his own people than from foreigners ought to build fortresses, but he who has more to fear from foreigners than from his own people ought not to build them. The castle of Milan, built by Francesco Sforza, has made more trouble for the house of Sforza, than has anything else in that state, and will continue to do so. For this reason the best possible fortress is this: not to be hated by the people. If the people hate you, even though you hold a fortress it will not save you, for there will always be foreigners to assist those of your people who have taken arms against you. In our time we have not seen such fortresses to have been of use to any prince, with the exception of the Countess of Forli.¹ When the Count Girolamo, her consort, was killed, a fortress protected her from the attack of the people, and allowed her to wait for assistance from Milan, and thus recover her state. Given the way things stood at that time, foreigners could not assist the people who had attacked her. But fortresses were of little value to her afterwards when Cesare Borgia attacked her, and when the people, who were opposed to her, had foreigners as allies. Therefore it would have been safer for her, both then and before, not to have been hated by the people than to have had the fortresses. All these things considered, then, I praise the prince who builds fortresses as well as the one who does not, and I blame the prince who, trusting in them, does not care about being hated by the people.

¹ *Countess of Forli* Catherine Sforza (1463–1509) held power in Forli after her husband was assassinated in 1488, until the city was taken by Cesare Borgia in 1500.

Chapter 21: *How a prince should act in order to gain esteem*

Nothing makes a prince more esteemed than great undertakings which demonstrate how extraordinary he is. We have in our time Ferdinand of Aragon, the present King of Spain. He can almost be called a new prince, because he has risen, by fame and glory, from being an insignificant king to be the foremost king in Christendom. If you will consider his deeds you will find them all great and some of them extraordinary. In the beginning of his reign he attacked Granada, and this enterprise was the foundation of his dominions. He did this quietly at first and without any fear of opposition, for he kept the barons of Castile occupied with the war so that they did not consider rebellion. They did not perceive that by these means he was acquiring power and authority over them. He was able to sustain his armies with the help of money from the Church and from the people, in that long war he laid the foundation for the military organization which has since distinguished him. Further, he always used religion for the furtherance of his greater schemes; he devoted himself with a pious cruelty to driving the Moors from his kingdom.¹ There could be no more remarkable example of the way he behaved than this. Under the same cloak of religion, he attacked Africa. He then invaded Italy and finally attacked France. His achievements and designs have always been great, and have kept the minds of his people in suspense and wonder, preoccupied with question of how they will turn out. And his actions have followed each other so closely that men have never had time to work steadily against him.

It helps that a prince display outstanding examples of ability in internal affairs, such as those told of Bernabo da Milano.² When he had the opportunity, he would find some way to reward or punish anyone in civil life who did some extraordinary good or bad thing; this would be widely discussed. And a prince ought, above all else, to try by every action to gain the reputation of being a great and remarkable man.

A prince is also respected when he is either a true friend or a true enemy—that is, when, he declares himself, with-

out any reservation, to be in favor of one party or against another. This course will always be more advantageous than staying neutral. The reason for this is that when two of your powerful neighbors come to blows, you either have to fear the conqueror or not. In either case it will always be more advantageous for you to declare your allegiance and to make war openly.

In the first case, in which you fear the conqueror, if you have not declared yourself, you will invariably fall a prey to the conqueror, to the pleasure and satisfaction of the conquered party. You will have no excuses or protection or shelter. A conqueror does not want doubtful friends who would not aid him in the time of trial; and a loser will not shelter you; you did not willingly, sword in hand, share his fate.

Antiochus³ went into Greece, being sent for by the Aetolians to drive out the Romans. He sent envoys to the Achaeans, who were friends of the Romans, exhorting them to remain neutral; on the other side, the Romans urged them to take up arms. This question was discussed in the council of the Achaeans, where the legate of Antiochus urged them to remain neutral. To this the Roman legate answered: "As for what has been said, that it is better and more advantageous for your state not to interfere in our war, nothing can be more erroneous; by not interfering you will be left, without favor or consideration, to be the prize of the conqueror."⁴ It will always happen that he who is not your friend will demand your neutrality, while he who is your friend will entreat you to declare yourself with arms. Irresolute princes, to avoid present dangers, generally follow the neutral path, and most of the time come to ruin. But when a prince declares himself gallantly in favor of one side, if the party with whom he allies himself conquers, he is indebted to him, even though the victor may be powerful and may have him at his mercy. A bond of friendship has been established, and men are never so shameless as to show such ingratitude by oppressing an ally. Victories after all are never so complete that the victor must not show some regard, especially to justice. But if he with whom you ally yourself loses, you may be sheltered by him, and while he is able he may aid you, and you become companions in a fortune that may rise again.

1 *driving ... his kingdom* Commentators think Machiavelli was referring to the choice given to Muslims in Granada of baptism or exile from the city.

2 *Bernabo da Milano* Bernabó Visconti, ruler of the territories of Milan from 1354 to 1385.

3 *Antiochus* King of Syria (223–187 BCE), frequently involved in battles with Rome.

4 *As for what ... the conqueror* This account is based on that in Livy, *History of Rome*, 35, 49.

In the second case, when you need not fear either of the fighting parties winning, it is even more prudent to be allied, because you assist in the destruction of one prince by another. If he had been wise, he would not have gone to war at all. Since it would have been impossible for him to conquer without your assistance, he will be in your debt.

Here it is to be noted that a prince ought to take care never to make an alliance with one more powerful than himself for the purpose of attacking others, unless necessity compels him to do so. As has been said above, if he conquers, you are under his power, and princes ought to avoid this whenever possible. The Venetians joined with France against the Duke of Milan, and this alliance, which caused their ruin, could have been avoided. But when it cannot be avoided, as happened to the Florentines when the Pope and Spain sent armies to attack Lombardy, then in such a case, for the above reasons, the prince ought to favor one of the parties.

No state should ever believe that it can always choose safe courses of action; rather it should expect that many actions will be risky. It is an everyday fact that in seeking to avoid one danger, one often runs into another. Prudence consists in knowing how to judge the nature of difficulties and risks, and to choose the least damaging path.

A prince ought also to show himself a patron of virtue, and to honor the proficient in every art. At the same time he should encourage his citizens to practice their callings peacefully, in commerce and agriculture, and in every other field, so that no one would be deterred from increasing his wealth for fear that it would be taken away, or from setting up a trade for fear of taxes. The prince ought to reward those who seek honor or enrich their city or state in any way.

Further, he ought to entertain the people with festivals and shows at appropriate times of the year. And, since every city is divided into guilds or groups, he ought to hold such bodies in esteem, and meet with them sometimes, and offer himself as an example of courtesy and generosity—maintaining, nevertheless, the majesty of his rank, which he must never, above all, permit to be doubted.

Chapter 22: Concerning princes' advisors

The choice of ministers is of no little importance to a prince, and they are good or bad depending on his prudence. The first impression one forms of a prince, and of his understanding, comes from observing the men he has around

him. When they are capable and faithful he may always be considered wise; he has shown that he knows how to recognize the capable and to keep them faithful. But when they are otherwise one cannot form a good opinion of him; for the first error he has made is their selection.

Everyone who knew Antonio da Venafrò when he was minister of Pandolfo Petrucci, Prince of Siena, would consider Pandolfo to be a very clever man for having chosen Venafrò for his minister. For there are three classes of intellects: one which comprehends by itself; another which appreciates what others comprehend; and a third which comprehends neither by itself nor through the intelligence of others. The first is the most excellent, the second is good, the third is useless. Therefore, it follows necessarily that, if Pandolfo was not in the first rank, he was at least in the second. For a prince may have the judgment to recognize good or bad in other men, even though he himself may not have any original ideas. If he can recognize the good and the bad in his minister, and praise the good and correct the bad. Thus his servant cannot hope to deceive him, and continues to act well.

There is one test which never fails when a prince wishes to form an opinion of his minister. When you see the minister thinking more of his own interests than of yours, and seeking his own happiness and profit, you may know such a man will never make a good minister, and you will never be able to trust him. He who is responsible for a prince's state ought never to think of himself, but always of his prince. He should never pay any attention to matters in which the prince is not concerned.

On the other hand, to keep his minister honest, the prince ought to pay attention to him, honor him, enrich him, share with him honors as well as duties, and thereby place him in his debt. At the same time, let him see that he cannot stand alone, so that many honors not make him desire more, many riches do not make him wish for more, and many duties do not make him fearful of changes. When princes and ministers have this sort of relationship, they can trust each other. But when it is otherwise, the end will always be disastrous for either one or the other.

Chapter 23: How to avoid flatterers

I do not wish to leave out an important issue concerning a danger from which it is difficult to save princes, unless they are very careful and discriminating. The danger comes from flatterers, and courts are full of them. Men are so self-

satisfied, and so easily deceived about their own affairs that it is difficult to save them from this plague. If they wish to defend themselves they run the risk of becoming despised, because there is no other way of protecting oneself from flatterers except by letting men understand that you will not be offended if they tell the truth. But when everyone tells you the truth, you lose respect.

Therefore a wise prince ought to take a third course by choosing the wise men in his state, and giving the liberty of speaking the truth to him only to them. Even then, they should be allowed to speak frankly only on those subjects about which he inquires, and about no others. But he ought to question them about everything, and listen to their opinions, and afterwards come to his own conclusions. With these councils and with each of these advisors individually, he ought to conduct himself in such a way that each of them should know that, the more freely he speaks, the more preference he earns. Other than these advisors, the prince should listen to no one; rather, he should pursue what he resolves on doing, and be steadfast in his resolutions. He who does otherwise is either overthrown by flatterers, or so often changes his mind that others lose respect for him.

I wish on this subject to cite a modern example. The present emperor Maximilian's¹ agent, Father Luca, speaking of his majesty, said that the emperor consulted no one, yet never got his own way in anything. This arose because of his following a practice opposite to the above. The emperor is a secretive man—he does not communicate his plans to anyone or receive opinions on them. But as his plans become revealed when he begins to act on them, the men around him at once mount opposition to them, and he, being pliant, is diverted from them. Hence it follows that those things he does one day he undoes the next, and no one ever understands what he wishes or intends to do, and no one can rely on his resolutions.

A prince, therefore, ought always to take counsel, but only when he wishes and not when others wish. He ought rather to discourage everyone from offering him advice unless asked. However, he ought to be a constant inquirer, and afterwards a patient listener concerning the things he has inquired about. Also, if he learns that anyone, for any reason, has not told him the truth, he should let his anger be felt.

Anyone is mistaken who thinks that a prince who impresses people as wise does so through the good advisers that he has around him, rather than through his own ability. This is an axiom which never fails: a prince who is not wise himself will never take good advice, unless by chance he has yielded his affairs entirely to someone else to act on his behalf as a governor—one person who happens to be a very prudent man. In this case the prince may doubtless govern well, but not for long; such a governor would soon take the prince's state away from him.

But if a prince who is not experienced should take counsel from more than one advisor, he will never get the same advice, and will not know how to reconcile the conflicting advice. Each of the counselors will think of his own interests, and the prince will not know how to control his counselors or to see through them. One cannot find counselors who are different from this; men will always prove untrue to you unless they are kept honest by constraint. Therefore it must be inferred that good advice, whatever its origin, must arise from the wisdom of the prince; but the wisdom of the prince does not arise from good advice.

Chapter 24: Why the princes of Italy have lost their states

The suggestions I have made, when observed carefully, will enable a new prince to appear well established, and render him immediately more secure and fixed in the state than if he had possessed it for a long time. For the actions of a new prince are more closely observed than those of a hereditary one, and when these actions demonstrate good ability, they gain the prince more adherents, and bind them to him far tighter than ancient blood. The reason for this is that men are attracted more by the present than by the past, and when they find the present good they enjoy it and seek no further; so they will defend a prince to the utmost so long as he does not neglect his duties. Thus it will be a double glory to him to have established a new principality, and adorned and strengthened it with good laws, a good army, good allies, and good actions; and so it will be a double disgrace to him who, born a prince, shall lose his state through lack of wisdom.

If one considers those rulers who have lost their states in Italy in our times, such as the King of Naples, the Duke of Milan, and others, there will be found the following: First, a common defect with regard to armies, the causes of which have been discussed at length. Second, some of them will be observed either to have faced hostility from the people; or if the people were friendly, from the nobles. In

¹ *Maximilian* Maximilian I (1450–1519), Holy Roman Emperor and King of Germany. His involvement in the Italian wars was motivated by his ambition to increase the dominion of the Habsburgs.

the absence of these defects, states that have enough power to keep an army in the field cannot be lost.

Philip of Macedon, not the father of Alexander the Great,¹ but he who Titus Quintius conquered,² had not much territory compared to the Romans and Greece who attacked him. Yet being a warlike man who knew how to attract the people and secure the nobles, he defended against his enemies for many years, and if in the end he lost rule over some of his colonies, nevertheless he retained his kingdom.

Those princes who have ruled for many years, but then have been ousted, should not blame bad luck for their loss; it is due instead to their own laziness. In quiet times they never thought there could be a change (it is a common defect in man not to make any provision for storms when the weather is good), and when the bad times came they thought of fleeing and not of defending themselves, and in hope that the people, disgusted with the insolence of the conquerors, would recall them. When other courses of action fail, this one may be good, but it is very bad to have neglected all other means; trusting that someone will later lift you back up should never make you willing to fall. Either you will not be lifted up, or if you are, you will not be secure in your position, because you have relied on this for restoration. Only those means which depend solely on yourself and your own abilities are reliable, certain, and durable.

Chapter 25: Of fortune's power in human affairs, and how to deal with her

I know that many men have had, and still have, the opinion that events in this world are controlled by fortune and by God, that men cannot manage them by prudence, and that no one can in any way affect them. Because of this they urge that one not work to change things, saying that everything should be left to chance. This belief has become more widespread in our times because of the great upheavals in human affairs which have taken place—and still are, every day, beyond all human prediction. When I think of this, I am sometimes inclined to agree to some extent. Nevertheless, so as not to deny our free will, I hold the position that fortune manages only half our actions, and still allows us to direct the other half (or perhaps a little less).

I compare her to one of those raging rivers, which when in flood overflows the plains, sweeping away trees and buildings, removing the earth from one place and depositing it at another, everyone flees before it, all yield to its violence, without being able to withstand it in any way. Although that is the way it is, it does not follow therefore that men, when the weather becomes calm, cannot not make provisions using embankments and dikes, so that when the waters rise again, they will be channeled off, and their force will not be so unrestrained and dangerous. So it happens with fortune, who shows her power where no measures have been prepared to resist her. She turns her forces to where she knows that embankments and dikes have not been built to restrain her.

If you will consider Italy, which is the seat of these changes, and which has provided their impetus, you will see that it is a country without embankments and dikes—without any defense. If it had been defended by proper measures, as are Germany, Spain, and France, either this invasion would not have caused the great changes it has made, or it would not have come at all. And with this I consider I have said enough about resistance to fortune in general.

But confining myself more to the particular, I say that a prince may live happily today but be ruined tomorrow, without having changed in his disposition or character. This, I believe, arises primarily from causes that have already been discussed at length—namely, that the prince who relies entirely upon fortune is lost when it changes. I believe also that he who directs his actions according to the spirit of the times will be successful, and that he whose actions do not accord with the times will not be successful. We can observe that men attempting to achieve what is everyone's aim—glory and riches—get there by various methods. One achieves that aim with caution, another with haste; one by force, another by skill; one by patience, another by its opposite; and each one succeeds in reaching the goal by a different method. We can also observe two cautious men, one of whom achieves his aims, while another does not; likewise, we can observe two equally successful men with different temperaments—one cautious, the other impetuous. All this arises simply from whether or not their methods conform to the spirit of the times. This follows from what I have said, that two men working differently can bring about the same effect, and of two working similarly, one may attain his object, while the other does not.

Changes in prosperity also result from this. Given a certain sort of convergence of times and affairs, careful and

¹ *the father of Alexander the Great* Philip II of Macedon (382–336 BCE).

² *he who Titus Quintius conquered* Philip V of Macedon (238–179 BCE).

patient management is called for, and one who acts in this way succeeds. But if times and affairs change, he is ruined if he does not change his course of action. Men are seldom sufficiently prudent to be able to accommodate themselves to such a change, both because they cannot deviate from their naturally-arising inclinations, and also because, if they have always prospered by acting in one way, they cannot be persuaded that it is a good idea to change. So the cautious man, when it is time to turn adventurous, does not know how to do it, and so he is ruined; had he changed his conduct with the times, Fortune would not have changed.

Pope Julius II¹ proceeded impetuously in all his affairs, and found the times and circumstances suited so well that line of action that he always met with success. Consider his first enterprise against Bologna, when Giovanni Bentivogli was still alive. The Venetians were unhappy with it, as was the King of Spain, and he was still negotiating with the King of France. Nevertheless he personally entered upon the expedition with his accustomed ferocity and energy, a move which made Spain and the Venetians stand indecisive and passive, the latter from fear, the former from their desire to recover all the kingdom of Naples. On the other hand, Julius drew after him the King of France, because that king, having observed his move and desiring to make the Pope his friend in order to defeat the Venetians, found it impossible to refuse him soldiers without openly offending him. Julius with his impetuous action accomplished what no other pontiff with simple human wisdom could have done; if he had waited in Rome until he could go ahead with everything arranged, as any other pontiff would have done, he would never have succeeded. The King of France would have made a thousand excuses, and the others would have raised a thousand fears.

I will not discuss his other actions alone, as they were all alike, and they all succeeded; his short life did not let him experience the contrary. But if circumstances had arisen which required him to go cautiously, his ruin would have followed, because he would never have deviated from those ways to which nature inclined him.

I conclude that, since fortune changes and men remain obstinate in their ways, men prosper when the two are in agreement and languish when they are not. For my part I consider that it is better to be adventurous than cautious,

because fortune is a woman, and if you wish to keep her under control it is necessary to beat and mistreat her. It has been observed that she allows herself to be mastered by the adventurous rather than by those who go to work more coldly. She is, therefore, always, like a woman, a lover of young men, because they are less cautious, more violent, and command her more boldly.

Chapter 26: An exhortation to liberate Italy from the barbarians

I have carefully considered the subject of the above discourses, and have been wondering whether the present times are propitious to a new prince, and whether the elements are in place that would give a wise and virtuous one the opportunity to introduce a new order of things which would honor him and benefit the people of this country. It appears to me that so many things concur to favor a new prince that I never knew a time more fit than the present.

If, as I said, it was necessary that the people of Israel should have been captive so as to demonstrate the ability of Moses; that the Persians needed to be oppressed by the Medes so as to discover the greatness of the soul of Cyrus; and that the Athenians should have been dispersed to illustrate the capabilities of Theseus: then at the present time, in order to reveal the ability of an Italian spirit, it was necessary that Italy should be reduced to her present condition, that she should be more enslaved than the Hebrews, more oppressed than the Persians, more scattered than the Athenians; without head, without order, beaten, despoiled, torn, overrun, and suffering every kind of ruin.

Although lately some glimmer of light may have been shown by one man, which made us think he was ordained by God for our redemption,² nevertheless it came to pass, in the height of his career, that fortune rejected him; so that Italy, left for dead, waits for the man who shall heal her wounds and put an end to the ravaging and plundering of Lombardy, to the swindling and taxing of the kingdom and of Tuscany, who shall cleanse those sores that have festered for so long. She entreats God to send someone who shall deliver her from barbaric cruelties and insolence. It appears that she is ready and willing to follow a banner if only someone will raise it.

Nor is there anyone in sight in whom she can place more hope than in your illustrious family, with its valor and

1 *Julius II* Pope (1443–1513) from 1503 until 1513. Known as the “Warrior Pope,” he effectively increased the power and holdings of the Church.

2 *one man ... redemption* Probably Cesare Borgia.

fortune, favored by God and by the Church of which it is now the chief, and which could lead this redemption. This will not be difficult if you recall the actions and lives of the men I have named.¹ Although they were great and wonderful men, yet they were men, and each one of them had no more opportunity than the present offers, for their enterprises were neither more just nor easier than this, nor was God more their friend than He is yours.

Here there is great justice, because “that war is just which is necessary, and arms are sacred when there is no other hope but in them.”² Here there is the greatest willingness, and where the willingness is great the difficulties cannot be great if you will only follow those men to whom I have directed your attention. Further than this, we see marvelous manifestations that God is directing you: the sea is divided, a cloud has led the way, the rock has poured forth water, it has rained manna,³ everything has contributed to your greatness; you must do the rest. God does not want to do everything—that would take away our free will and our share of the glory.

It is not surprising that none of the above-named Italians⁴ have been able to accomplish all that is expected from your illustrious family; nor that in so many revolutions in Italy, and in so many campaigns, military vigor has seemed to have been exhausted. This has happened because the old order of things was not good, and none of us has known how to find a new one. And nothing honors a man newly risen to power more than his establishment of new laws and institutions. When they are well founded and dignified, these new arrangements will make him revered and admired. In Italy there is no lack of opportunity to bring about these innovations in every form.

Here in Italy there is great power in the limbs—but not in the heads. Observe duels and hand-to-hand combat: see how superior the Italians are in strength, dexterity, and subtlety. But when it comes to armies they do not compare well. This arises entirely from the insufficiency of the leaders. Those with ability and knowledge are not obeyed, and each one thinks that he is knowledgeable, since there never has been anyone so outstanding in ability or luck that others

would yield to him. Hence it is that for so long a time, and during so much of the fighting in the past twenty years, whenever there has been a wholly Italian army, it has always given a poor account of itself. As proof of this, witness Taro, Alessandria, Capua, Genoa, Vaila, Bologna, Mestre.⁵

If, therefore, your illustrious family wishes to follow those remarkable men who have redeemed their country, it is necessary above all, as a true basis for every enterprise, to be provided with your own armed forces, because there can be no more faithful, true, or better soldiers. And although they are good individually, they will be much better when they find themselves commanded by their prince, honored by him, and maintained at his expense. Therefore it is necessary to be prepared with such forces, so that you can defend against foreigners with Italian valor.

Although Swiss and Spanish infantry may be considered very formidable, nevertheless both are defective, and as a result a third power could not only oppose them, but might even overthrow them. For the Spaniards cannot resist cavalry, and the Swiss are afraid of infantry whenever they offer resistance. Because of this, as we have seen and many continue to see, the Spaniards are unable to resist French cavalry, and the Swiss infantry can be decoyed by the Spanish infantry. Although a complete proof cannot be given of the Swiss weakness, there was some evidence of it at the battle of Ravenna,⁶ when the Spanish infantry were confronted by German battalions, who follow the same tactics as the Swiss. There the Spaniards, by agility of body and with the aid of their shields, got in under the pikes⁷ of the Germans and thus were out of danger and able to attack, while the Germans were helpless. If the cavalry had not raced up, the Spaniards would have slaughtered them all. It is possible, therefore, knowing the defects of both these infantries, to invent a new type, one that will resist cavalry and not be afraid of infantry. This need not be a new form of army; it may be simply a variation on the old. But these are the kind of improvements which confer reputation and power upon a new prince.

1 *the men I have named* Moses, Cyrus, Theseus.

2 *that war ... in them* This quotation is from Livy, *History of Rome*, 9. 1.

3 *the sea ... rained manna* These events are recounted in Exodus 14.17.

4 *the above-named Italians* It is not perfectly clear to whom Machiavelli refers; it may be Sforza and Borgia (Chapter 7) and perhaps in addition Pope Julius II (Chapter 11).

5 *Taro ... Mestre* The French were victorious in Taro (the Battle of Fornovo) in 1495; they sacked Alessandria in 1499 and Capua in 1501; they took Genoa in 1507, defeated the Venetians in Vailà (the battle of Agnadello) in 1509, and took Bologna in 1511. In 1513, Mestre, near Venice, was burned by an opposing alliance.

6 *the battle of Ravenna* A French victory in 1512.

7 *got in under the pikes* The German and Swiss soldiers held seventeen-foot-long horizontally-held pikes; one approached them only by ducking underneath these pikes.

The opportunity must not be allowed to pass for Italy to at last behold her liberator. One cannot express the love with which he would be received, in all those provinces which have suffered so much from foreign invasions. Nor can one readily express the thirst for revenge, the stubborn faith, the devotion, and the tears. What door would be closed to him? Who would refuse obedience to him? What envy would hinder him? What Italian would refuse him homage? The current barbarous domination stinks in everyone's nostrils. Let your illustrious family therefore take on this task with the courage and hope with which all just enterprises are undertaken, so that under its banner our native country may be ennobled, and under its auspices may be verified that saying of Petrarch: "Virtu contro al Furore Prendera l'arme, e fia il combatter corto: Che l'antico valore Negli italici cuor non e ancor morto."¹



Discourses on the First Ten Books of Titus Livius (1512–17)

*Niccolò Machiavelli to Zanobi
Buondelmonte and Cosima Rucellai*

Greeting

With this I send you a gift which, if it bears no proportion to the extent of the obligations which I owe you, is nevertheless the best that I am able to offer to you; for I have endeavored to embody in it all that long experience and assiduous research have taught me of the affairs of the world. And as neither yourselves nor anyone else can ask more than that of me, you cannot complain that I have not given you more; though you may well complain of my lack of talent when my arguments are poor, and of the fallacies of my judgment on account of the errors into which I have doubtless fallen many times. This being so, however, I know

not which of us has the greater right to complain—I, that you should have forced me to write what I should never have attempted of my own accord, or you, that I should have written without giving you cause to be satisfied.

Accept it, then, as one accepts whatever comes from friends, looking rather to the intention of him who gives, than to the thing offered. And believe me, that I feel a satisfaction in this, that, even if I have often erred in the course of this work, I have assuredly made no mistake in having chosen you above all other friends to whom to dedicate these discourses. In doing this, I give some proof of gratitude, although I may seem to have departed from the ordinary usage of writers, who generally dedicate their works to some prince; and, blinded by ambition or avarice, praise him for all the virtuous qualities he has not, instead of censuring him for his real vices, whilst I, to avoid this fault, do not address myself to such as are princes, but to those who by their infinite good qualities are worthy to be such; not to those who could load me with honors, rank, and wealth, but rather to those who have the desire to do so, but have not the power. For to judge rightly, men should esteem rather those who are, and not those who can be generous; and those who would know how to govern states, rather than those who have the right to govern, but lack the knowledge.

For this reason have historians praised Hiero of Syracuse,² a mere private citizen, more than Perseus of Macedon,³ monarch though he was; for Hiero only lacked a principality to be a prince, whilst the other had nothing of the king except the diadem. Be it good or bad, however, you wanted this work, and such as it is I send it to you; and should you continue in the belief that my opinions are acceptable to you, I shall not fail to continue to examine this history, as I promised you in the beginning of it. Farewell!

¹ *Virtu contro ... ancor morto* "Virtue against fury shall advance the fight, And in the combat soon shall it put to flight; For the old Roman, valor is not dead, Nor in the Italians' breasts extinguished" (Petrarch, "Italia mia," in Petrarch's letters: *Rerum Vulgarium Fragmenta*, 128 (1344?) 2, 93–96).

² *Hiero of Syracuse* Hiero II (307–216 BCE) was so successful as an army commander that he was elected king of Syracuse. The remark about lacking only a principality to be a prince is an inaccurate quotation from the Roman historian Justin. Machiavelli also mentions Hiero, and gives this quotation, in *The Prince*.

³ *Perseus of Macedon* (c. 212–166 BCE) Last king of Macedon, whose antagonistic actions toward Rome led to war in 171 BCE. After his defeat, he was imprisoned in Rome, and Macedon became a Roman possession.